

Chapter 1: Critical Narratives Undermine Punitive Bias Towards Urban Gun Violence Policies

Gun violence is the leading cause of death among young people in the U.S., with homicides accounting for over 60% of total gun deaths for ages 25 and under (CDC, 2021; Goldstick et al., 2021, 2022). However, like many American societal issues, a closer look at the data reveals major differences that disproportionately impact historically-minoritized groups (Bailey et al., 2017; Wildeman & Wang, 2017; Williams & Collins, 2001; Williams & Jackson, 2005). For example, Black Americans make up 13% of the population but account for 60% of all gun homicides, most of which occur in urban neighborhoods with high rates of poverty and racial segregation (CDC, 2021; Cheon et al., 2020; Frazer et al., 2017). Although gun violence is a widely-shared concern, experts disagree on how to prioritize public safety strategies (Cook & Ludwig, 2019; Gee, 2022; Ludwig & Shah, 2014; Wolf & Rosen, 2015). The dominant narratives about reducing gun violence focus on keeping guns and criminals off the streets through increased law enforcement (Braga et al., 2018; McGinty et al., 2014; The White House, 2022; Vasilogambros, 2022). However, punitive approaches can exacerbate the root causes of violence by further destabilizing neighborhoods that are already overly targeted by policing and mass incarceration (Futerman et al., 2016; Kovera, 2019; Lynch, 1997; Miller, 2022; National Research Council, 2014; Sampson et al., 2002; Wildeman & Wang, 2017). A restorative approach instead aims to repair the harm caused by a racist history of segregation, divestment, and disenfranchisement has caused to many of these neighborhoods (Alexander, 2010; Massey, 1993; Rothstein, 2017; Sampson et al., 2002; Williams & Collins, 2001; Williams & Mohammed, 2013). With this context in mind, restorative approaches seek to prevent violence by establishing routes for socioeconomic mobility and other positive support structures (Bieler et al., 2016; David-Ferdon et al., 2016; Edley et al., 2008; The Joyce Foundation, 2019, 2022; Tsui, 2014). The racial patterns in gun homicides and the history of systemic oppression suggest that reducing gun violence requires a critical examination of what it means to do so in an equitable manner.

This dissertation examines how certain narratives about racialized social problems can strengthen or remedy the structural and psychological factors that contribute to the problem. Using community gun violence (hereafter CGV)¹ as a problem space, I examine a psychological approach to shifting attitudes and behaviors that advance equity-oriented solutions. This approach is guided by critical social theories developed to arm scholars and the public to challenge the systemic mechanisms underlying racial inequities (Collins, 2019b; Crenshaw et al., 1995; Delgado & Stefancic, 2017; Freire, 1970; Lewin & Iowa Child Welfare Research Station, 1937). This introduction will describe the disadvantaging characteristics of conventional narratives about societal problems, followed by the comparable advantages of critical narratives as defined in this present work, and end with an overview of the experimental study conditions and hypotheses in Chapter 1.

Conventional narratives about societal problems reinforce inequalities

Narratives organize what information is most salient to audiences, which shapes lay beliefs about how a problem came to be and what solutions are appropriate (Druckman, 2001; Iyengar, 1991; Kim, 2015; Sotirovic, 2003). American narratives about societal issues have a history of presenting information from a perspective that is highly individualized, blind to how racial contexts shape experiences and perpetuate harmful racial stereotypes (Barry et al., 2013; Braga & Brunson, 2015; Parham-Payne, 2014; Perez & Salter, 2019; Roberts & Rizzo, 2020; Salter et al., 2016). In the following section, I describe how these characteristics ignore information that is critical for understanding societal issues in a way that represents the reality of the problem space.

Colorblindness suppresses historically-marginalized narratives When trying to make sense of societal problems, the presence or lack of contextual knowledge influences how a person explains outcomes and whether those explanations map onto reality. Racially colorblind narratives avoid considering race as a legitimate factor when analyzing issues, even in the face of clear racial patterns (Apfelbaum et al., 2012; Bonilla-Silva, 2015; Dupree & Kraus, 2021). In particular, colorblind narratives miss information and themes that emerge from historically-marginalized perspectives, such as *critical historical knowledge* about America's history of racism (Bonam et al., 2019; Nelson et al., 2013). Colorblind narratives can thus misrepresent the reality of racism and enable self-serving motivations that affect how people perceive current issues (Delgado & Stefancic, 2017; Kraus et al., 2019). For example, colorblindness

¹ Sometimes referred to as "urban," "street," or "inner city" gun violence, I use the term "community gun violence" to emphasize the largely social and neighborhood-based nature of this phenomenon (B. Green et al., 2017).

and a lack of critical knowledge lead to overestimating racial progress because it affirms beliefs about living in a fair, post-racial society (Jost, 2019; Kraus et al., 2019; Onyeador et al., 2020). Moreover, when shown counter-evidence of continuing racial inequality, rather than correcting overestimations of racial equality, participants downplayed the extent of past inequality (Onyeador et al., 2020).

Over-individualizing societal issues skews perceived causes Over-individualized narratives emphasize individual-level factors while ignoring significant contextual factors, which can emerge for several reasons. First, in the process of assessing causal factors, the information that is most salient gets interpreted as playing a larger role (Fiske et al., 1982). The accuracy of this process is vulnerable to cognitive shortcuts evolved to facilitate navigating an information-rich world Tetlock (2000). Generally, people underestimate the power of situations to influence behavior and are particularly quick to interpret others' poor behavior as more agentic and representative of their character (Gilbert et al., 1995; Ross & Nisbett, 1991; Tetlock, 1985). When explaining one's own behavior, however, the blame shifts towards situational circumstances and other self-knowledge that is salient to one's self but is less salient or invisible to others.

Similarly, narrative frames influence how viewers form causal explanations by manipulating the salience of information about individual characteristics compared to societal themes (Iyengar, 1991; Sotirovic, 2003). For example, an episodic narrative that communicates information through individuals' personal stories leads more viewers to understand societal issues as problems caused by personal failings for which they should be held responsible. In contrast, thematic narratives communicate abstract concepts as they connect to behavior and prompt greater blame towards societal structures. Individualistic narratives have been shown to influence causal attributions and policy preferences across societal issues such as obesity (Barry et al., 2013), poverty (Hannah & Cafferty, 2006; Piff et al., 2020), policing (Bowleg et al., 2021), and racism (Pew Research Center, 2016; Rucker & Richeson, 2021a).

Stereotypes substitute information gaps In a problem space stripped of context through colorblind, individualized narratives, people draw from personal experiences and pre-existing mental models to explain others' behavior. High rates of racial segregation in the U.S., however, increase the physical and psychological distance between groups' experiences (Massey, 1993; Rothstein, 2017; Salter & Adams, 2016; Steele & Sherman, 1999; Trope & Liberman, 2010). These differences in physical environments and lived experiences impact how a person can afford to make sense of the world and human behaviors (Steele & Sherman, 1999; Walton & Yeager, 2019). In this sense, someone with first-hand experience living through the consequences of societal problems can afford to call on more factors to understand related behaviors than someone who does not (Roberts & Rizzo, 2020; Salter & Adams, 2016; Steele & Sherman, 1999; Walton & Yeager, 2019). For those who cannot afford such nuanced understandings, potential causal factors are limited to representations of the affected group seen in mainstream narratives. Reliance on mainstream representations of marginalized groups for accuracy, however, is not ideal. Whether delivered through entertainment or news reports, racial stereotypes are made salient when the public receives racially-coded information (Banaji et al., 2021; Hurwitz & Peffley, 1997, 2005). Popular media promotes racial stereotypes that influence attitudes towards stigmatized groups and the issues affecting them (Bjornstrom et al., 2010; Dixon & Linz, 2000; Gilens, 1996b; Hurwitz & Peffley, 1997, 2005; Oliver, 2003).

These phenomena perpetuate inequity and feed the cycle of violence The above section described how conventional narratives marginalize critical information that shapes lay beliefs about how the world works. The following section describes how these lay beliefs undermine policy support for repairing systems that reproduce racial inequities. Garnering support for effective policy solutions depends largely on public attitudes about the causal nature of a social problem. (Brown-Iannuzzi et al., 2017; Dunbar, 2020; Haider-Markel & Joslyn, 2001; Parham-Payne, 2014; Wozniak, 2019). For example, individualistic attributions predict opposition to welfare policies, whereas societal attributions predict support for social service spending (Iyengar, 1991; Sotirovic, 2003). In contrast, societal blame yields sympathy that translates into a greater willingness to support the victims (Cuddy et al., 2008; Haider-Markel et al., 2018). People generally approve of social support services and rehabilitative policies to reduce crime. However, people are more likely to prefer harsher punishments when the decision is in response to "Black crime" (Hetey & Eberhardt, 2014, 2018). This shift has been linked to how stereotype-consistent cues shape policy preferences towards disproportionately punishing Black men. Conclusions about how "deserving" a person is of correctional punishment or how "undeserving" they are of public assistance are an automatic response

that is influenced by stereotypical beliefs of Black people as dangerous or lazy, respectively (Bridges & Steen, 1998; Brown-Iannuzzi et al., 2017; Gilens, 1996a, 1999).

When it comes to evaluating public policies that would primarily impact underserved communities of color, biased deservingness beliefs can impede constructive change by either increasing support for punitive actions against low-level crimes or decreasing support for social welfare, both of which are related to negative stereotypes about Black Americans (E. G. T. Green et al., 2006). The racial biases towards punitive support can be understood as a symptom of how mainstream narratives make stereotype-consistent information salient without including nuanced understandings of race. When left unchallenged, such lay beliefs are a psychological barrier to implementing policies intended to reduce racial disparities through structural change [Geronimus (2000); Skinner-Dorkenoo et al. (2021)].

Critical narratives as an alternative approach

This present approach is grounded in critical social theories developed to empower scholars and the public to understand and disrupt norms that whitewash root causes of social inequities (Collins, 2019b; Crenshaw et al., 1995; Delgado & Stefancic, 2017; Freire, 1970). Critical Race Theory (hereafter CRT) is a seminal framework originated by legal scholars to interrogate how the social construct of race is imbued with power throughout fundamental societal institutions (Crenshaw et al., 1995; Delgado & Stefancic, 1992, 2017). Scholars and practitioners across education (Ladson-Billings, 1995; Lynn & Dixon, 2013; Solórzano & Yosso, 2002), psychology (Crossing et al., 2022; Diemer et al., 2016; Salter & Adams, 2013; Torre et al., 2012), public health (Graham et al., 2011), and medicine (Metzl et al., 2018; Metzl & Petty, 2017; Tsai et al., 2021) have since adopted critically-conscious approaches that incorporate CRT principles and other themes related to challenging inequitable structures.

For this work, I define *critical narrative* as one that describes inequality by delivering marginalized information about structural oppression that is inconsistent with normative assumptions underlying societal inequities. The key components of a critical narrative are described in the following section and include: (A) centering marginalized perspectives, (B) recognizing structural racism as a problem, and (C) giving a clear, causal explanation of how structural racism impacts group outcomes. I argue that the problems of colorblindness, over-individualization, and racial stereotypes in mainstream narratives can be undermined by narratives that wisely deliver these critical components, even on a topic as controversial as racism and gun violence.

A. Centering of marginalized perspectives to counter normative narratives. When examining a problem space, the practice of centering perspectives from historically-marginalized groups affected by the issue can reveal pertinent themes and factors that could otherwise be washed away. Holistic analyses of the individual- and system-level factors surrounding a problem enable a richer understanding of behavior as it relates to external structure and norms (Bowleg et al., 2021; Collins, 2019a; Crenshaw et al., 2016; Geronimus, 2000; Gkiouleka et al., 2018). Critical narratives can begin to fill in the gaps by raising consciousness about the structural nature of racism and how it has significantly impacted mechanisms for full citizenship and socioeconomic mobility (Alexander, 2010; Bonilla-Silva, 1997; Crenshaw et al., 1995; Miller, 2022). This missing information facilitates policy approaches that look “upstream” to create preventative, sustainable, and effective solutions to problems that show patterns of systemic differences (Heath, 2020).

Counter-storytelling, a rhetorical tool of CRT, critiques colorblind narratives by presenting accounts from the lived experiences of marginalized groups, which often paints a fundamentally different picture of societal systems that are inconsistent with normative representations (Crenshaw et al., 1995). Perspectives from racially-marginalized groups introduce critical information that is inconsistent with overly-optimistic colorblind narratives about racial equality. By introducing new salient information about the relevant societal context, the counter-storytelling component of critical narratives can help override the prominence of stereotypes in public mental models.

B. Recognition of structural racism as a contributor to societal problems The conventional narratives miss critical information about the root causes of societal problems, as many stem from structural inequities. In particular, individualized colorblind narratives neglect the wealth of interdisciplinary evidence illustrating the extent of racism embedding in American institutional structures and social fabric Williams & Collins (2001). Critical narratives enrich the potential for developing equitable and effective solutions because they look upstream to address the underlying

mechanisms that tilt the scales (Heath, 2020). Structural racism plays a role in how social policy issues came to be and why they often disproportionately affect minority groups (Alexander, 2010; Bailey et al., 2017; Bonilla-Silva, 1997; Lawrence et al., 2008; Massey, 1993; Sampson et al., 2002; Williams & Collins, 2001; Williams & Mohammed, 2013). However, most Americans understand racism as an individual quality that exists in a racially-prejudiced person while underestimating racism in structures like laws and institutions (Banaji et al., 2021; Bonilla-Silva, 1997, 2003, 2015; Rucker, 2020; Rucker et al., 2020; Rucker & Richeson, 2021a; Rucker & Richeson, 2021b).

C. Explanation of how structural racism contributes to current issues A critical narrative can expand mental models of racism by illuminating systemic racial patterns to identify and repair underlying structures that uphold discriminatory processes. To be effective, however, the narrative must also explain how causal mechanisms of racial oppression influence marginalized experiences and produce different group-level outcomes. Critical consciousness, sometimes called structural competency, is the capacity to identify and navigate the structures underlying social inequities in pursuit of equity-oriented goals (Diemer et al., 2016; Freire, 1970; Metzl et al., 2018; Metzl & Petty, 2017). For example, teaching “structural competency” to medical residents resulted in more effective patient care than the control group (Metzl et al., 2018; Metzl & Petty, 2017). In this context, learning how laws and institutions operated to marginalize groups afforded medical residents greater contextual knowledge to better understand how patterns in socioeconomic circumstances relate to patients’ health behaviors (e.g., inability to visit pharmacy outside of work hours or missing appointments because of unreliable public transportation.) This consciousness about the causal history behind racial inequalities can help correct implicit biases from narrative structures and contents that neglect this critical context.

Applying critical narratives to community gun violence

Critical narratives can be used to understand complex phenomena, like how structural forces transmit (dis)advantage by shaping institutions, laws, and social norms. For this dissertation chapter, I created news articles and policy memos that provided information about gun violence in some “poor communities of color” that differed by key components of a critical narrative. In exploring how people come to understand why gun violence is such a problem in some poor communities of color, I expect a critical narrative to undermine the colorblind, individualistic, and misrepresentations of Black Americans that bias attitudes and behaviors. The following section describes how I apply the above elements of critical narratives to CGV as a problem space.

A. Centers marginalized perspectives to counter normative narratives Not only are conventional narratives not capturing the full story, but they are also missing evidence of how the traditional prescriptions for reducing violence in this context amplify underlying causes of CGV. Punitive models of crime deterrence use fear-based threats and incapacitation as primary mechanisms of violence reduction. These levers, however, are disproportionately used against marginalized communities to a devastating degree (Alexander, 2010; Massey, 1993, 2020; Rothstein, 2017; Wildeman & Wang, 2017). Over-policing and mass incarceration of poor neighborhoods of color destabilize family and community structures, which fosters patterns of violence (Alexander, 2010; Miller, 2022; National Research Council, 2014; Sampson et al., 2002; Smiley & Fakunle, 2016; Swisher & Shaw-Smith, 2015). Police presence is often seen as a threat to one’s safety rather than protective service due to disproportionate arrests of people of color and accounts of racial discrimination (Futerman et al., 2016; Schutz, 2016; Wacquant, 2002).

B. Recognizes structural contributors to societal problems Regarding gun violence in the U.S., mainstream narratives often emphasize individual traits like mental illness or personal histories, which prompt support for solutions that prevent the most “at-risk” individuals from accessing guns (Gallup et al., 2019; Haider-Markel & Joslyn, 2001; Lu & Temple, 2019; McGinty et al., 2014). Individualized narratives on CGV are particularly problematic because there are centuries of strategic campaigns to sabotage the image of the “hearts and minds” of young Black men (Smiley & Fakunle, 2016). In addition, significant situational and structural contributing factors to CGV directly and indirectly shape the problem space. A critical narrative highlights the significant situational and structural contributing factors to that directly and indirectly shape the problem space of CGV. For example, the extreme rates of gun violence in some Black communities are a symptom of historical inequities that restrict access to basic needs, civil rights, and paths to socioeconomic mobility (Alexander, 2010; Knopov et al., 2019). This information is considered critical because it communicates insights about root causes that are key to informing preventative, upstream solutions.

C. Explains how structural racism contributes to current issues However, this critical information about structural racism can only be expected to counter inferences that rely on stereotypes if it explains why racism is a relevant factor in the first place. In the context of CGV, critical narratives can draw on scholarship that explains how overtly racist policies and practices that infringe on Black American's opportunities to get ahead, such as "The New Jim Crow: Mass Incarceration in the Age of Colorblindness" (Alexander, 2010), "The Case for Reparations" (Coates, 2014), and "The Color of Law" (Rothstein, 2017). For example, critical connections can be made by describing hidden political agendas behind the War on Drugs, which fueled the mass incarceration of Black men for minor drug crimes despite being less likely than Whites to use or sell drugs. Racial discrimination carried out through housing and policing can be described as two major factors that restrict the ability of Black Americans to pursue stable housing and legal employment, which increases pressure to seek income through illegal means and gun carrying for protection.

Additional considerations when developing critical narratives

For these reasons, I expect a critical narrative about CGV will shift attitudes and behaviors related to what is causing this problem and what is needed to fix it equitably. The following section describes two additional theoretical strategies I applied in developing narratives.

Values-alignment One glaring challenge to this expectation is that gun violence, policing, and racism are high-profile topics that trigger sharp identity-based divides (Jost, 2017; Pew Research Center, 2016, 2019; Unzueta & Lowery, 2008). Moreover, current U.S. politics are extremely divisive, with much political information being communicated via echo chambers that pander to ingroup ideals (Hetherington & Rudolph, 2015; Pew Research Center, 2014). Desires to signal that one is "anti-racist," for example, have risen since the racial uprisings of 2020. Although normalizing anti-racism is valuable for advancing equitable policies, doing so naively often obscures the structural construal of racism that is foundational in critical narratives. As a result, politicized terms like "structural racism" and "critical race theory" can be easily misconstrued because they are used as naive buzzwords to gain favor without needing to unpack the concept.

Values-alignment is a behavior change strategy that frames prescriptive messages as consistent with salient, existing values of the intended audience (Bryan et al., 2019; Bryan et al., 2016). A narrative that naively invokes anti-racist language to deliver critical information about CGV may prompt strong reactance, raising the likelihood of conservatives rejecting the content altogether. I used a values-alignment strategy to mitigate reactance associated with political and racial identities by presenting information in a way that minimizes language that could signal goals that are inconsistent with salient political values. A values-alignment approach does not attempt persuasion by convincing people to change their pre-existing values as identity-threats impede efforts to change racially-charged attitudes, such as perceptions of inequality (e.g., Onyeador et al., 2020).

Although one might expect critical narratives to increase critical consciousness, the present narratives discuss controversial topics in the context of a societal problem that does not directly impact the large majority of the population. I would expect greater identity-based reactance from critical narratives that expose inequities in a context that could potentially implicate participants' identities and positions of privilege. For these reasons, I expect to critical narrative to shift policy preferences regardless of political orientation or level of critical consciousness.

Problem-posing *Problem-posing* is a pedagogical strategy that creates a psychological space that affords the possibility to process new information as it relates to an explicit prosocial goal. Creating a problem-solving space through a countering perspective licenses the ability to suspend existing mental models and build new ones from the ground up. Without this stated goal, readers may be more likely to pursue implicit goals to maintain a positive sense of self (Unzueta & Lowery, 2008). I expect that delivering critical information through problem-posing will allow readers to process potentially-threatening information in a way that would not be afforded if the information was assumed to have persuasive intent. Taken together, I expect a critical narrative that poses a problem and appeals to shared intergroup values can deliver controversial information without the associated sociopolitical baggage hanging onto the normative mental model.

Present Research

This dissertation seeks to use critical narratives to disrupt the process in which how mainstream narratives reinforce psychological and structural processes that maintain racial inequity. Chapter 1 explores the impact of adopting critically-informed narratives that run counter to conventional narratives when discussing racial inequalities, such as the issue of “gun violence in poor communities of color.” A series of experimental studies test whether a critical narrative about the causal connection between CGV and racism influences support for punitive versus restorative approaches to reducing violence, compared to (a) individualized narratives that explain how individual deficiencies in socioemotional skills lead to gun violence, (b) naïve anti-racist narratives that blame structural racism without explaining the causal mechanisms, and (c) control narratives that do not provide any additional context on CGV. The theoretical differences between conditions across the studies in Chapter 1 are as follows:

Control condition. All narratives begin by comparing the national conversations on mass shootings to the daily gun violence experienced in some poor neighborhoods of color. This introduction establishes a counter-space to the dominant narratives by identifying a related yet overlooked concern. The control condition narratives point out the racial pattern of CGV but do not (A) provide context about the affected group's lived experiences, (B) recognize structural racism as a contributing factor to CGV, or (C) explain its causal impact. This condition establishes a reference point that captures spontaneous beliefs about gun violence without exposure theoretically-relevant factors.

Critical condition. The critical narratives include the same introduction, (A) adds context about the affected group's experiences, and (B) recognizes how structural racism fostered conditions that create risks for gun violence. Importantly, the critical narratives also (C) provide causal explanations of how racism yields unequal group outcomes through external systems that transmit disadvantage.

Individual condition. Like the critical condition, the individual condition stimuli also (A) centers the experiences of marginalized group. It does not (B) recognize structural racism as a causal factor, nor does it (C) explain how structural racism raised the risk of violence by shaping the affected groups' environment and circumstances. Note that the individual condition does not present an episodic narrative that tells the story from the perspective of one or more individuals. Instead, it presents a thematic narrative about the patterns of CGV along with information about situational pressures individuals face. The individualized narratives do not, however, label or explain the structures underlying individuals' surrounding context.

Naïve anti-racist condition. The naïve condition presents narratives that (A) raise awareness of marginalized groups' experiences and (B) declare structural racism as a contributing factor to social problems, but do not (C) explain this politically controversial claim. Unlike the critical narrative, I designed the naïve anti-racist narratives to include politicized buzzwords to signal alignment with liberal values. Comparison with this condition is expected to emphasize the need to explain critical concepts from a bottom-up, counter-cultural perspective.

Hypotheses

- H1a. Participants in the critical condition will report reduced support for punitive policies. This main effect will emerge across levels of political ideology (b).
- H2a. Participants in the critical condition will report increased support for restorative policies. This main effect will emerge across levels of political ideology (b).
- H3a. Participants in the critical condition will score lower on a modern racism scale (b).
- H4. Reduced modern racism will partially mediate the critical main effects on reduced punitive policy support (a) and increased restorative policy support (b).
- H5. Participants in the critical condition will express behaviors and intentions for policy support in terms of budget allocation (a), engagement with a related petition (b), and willingness to share the gun violence narrative on social media (c).
- H6. The critical condition will increase the extent to which attribute gun violence to structural factors (a) and decrease attributions to dispositional factors (b).
- H7. Structural attributions for CGV will partially mediate the critical main effects on reduced punitive policy (a) support and increased restorative policy support (b).

Study 1: A critical narrative reduces support for punitive violence prevention policies

Study 1 investigates whether reading information about the causal contributors to CGV can shift public policy preferences and attributions for the racial patterns in CGV. The study is a 3 x 1 between-subjects design, in which participants are randomly assigned to one of three conditions: critical, individual, and control. The main hypotheses are:

- H1a. Participants in the critical condition will report reduced support for punitive policies. This main effect will emerge across levels of political ideology (b).
- H2a. Participants in the critical condition will report increased support for restorative policies. This main effect will emerge across levels of political ideology (b).
- H3a. Participants in the critical condition will score lower on a modern racism scale (b).
- H4. Reduced modern racism will partially mediate the critical main effects on reduced punitive policy support (a) and increased restorative policy support (b).

Method

A total of 601 online participants were recruited to complete a 15-minute survey ($M = 14.07$, $SD = 7.72$) for \$1.50 on Amazon Mechanical Turk in Fall 2019. There were no significant differences in survey duration between conditions ($F(2,598) = 1.21$, $p = .300$). The sample was 49% female, 77% White, 10% Black, 8% Latiné, 9% Asian, 0% Middle Eastern, and 2% of Native or Indigenous descent, with a median adjusted household income of \$34,641.02 ($M = 35670.22$, $SD = 21727.51$).

The survey randomized participants to read an ostensibly real Wall Street Journal article that delivered on of the three conditional narratives. The key differences were that the critical narrative described how structural racism contributes to CGV, while the individualized narrative instead focuses on how individual differences in self-control contribute to CGV, and the control provided no additional information. Participants in the control condition were asked to participate in a study about vaping and a separate study about gun violence.

All news articles ended with three manipulation check questions that asked participants to recall details about the causal claims made in the article. Participants who answered at least one question incorrectly were redirected to the news article page and asked to review, and then tried answering again. After three failed attempts, the survey allowed participants to continue the survey, but their data were excluded from analyses. The survey then presented the policy support items, followed by questions about policy preferences regarding gun violence in “poor neighborhoods of color.” All items were randomized within their section. After completing the main survey measures, the survey debriefed the nature of the study and its use of fake news articles. The statement provided links to sources and explained that the claims made in the articles were supported by credible news outlets and peer-reviewed journal articles.

Materials

See Study 1 Appendix for full materials.

Critical narrative The critical news article titled “Chicago’s Gun Violence is Deeply Rooted in Racial Segregation and Mass Incarceration” presented evidence from scholars and public health experts about how a history of racism fostered societal conditions that led to high rates of gun violence in some Black communities. The article describes how U.S. banks officiated racial discrimination in lending practices and housing regulations, which created pockets of concentrated poverty that made it nearly impossible for families to escape. The author provides evidence of hidden agendas behind a discriminatory shift in policing practices and provides statistical evidence of racial discrimination in the criminal justice system. The critical article ends with a gun violence expert advocating for policies that target the physical, economic, or social structures in neighborhoods with gun violence to repair the damage done by racism. The recommendations included affordable housing regulation, local business construction, public education, and better community-police relations.

Individual narrative The individualized article “Chicago’s Gun Violence is Deeply Rooted in Self-Control Issues” describes this issue with a focus on how individual traits raise the risk of experiencing gun violence. It argues that the above-average rates of gun violence in poor, Black neighborhoods are due to young residents developing a disposition to react impulsively and aggressively towards others. The article ends by advocating for socioemotional development programs that teach kids how to resolve conflicts peacefully. The individual article ends by advocating for socioemotional development programs that teach kids how to peacefully resolve conflicts, improve decision-making skills, and internalize values of self-determination and integrity.

Control Participants in the control condition were told that they would be participating in two separate studies. The “first study” presented the control article on vaping and manipulation check questions. After passing through the manipulation checks, the survey asked participants if they currently vaped and thanked them for completing the first study. The survey then directed them to the second survey on gun violence in poor communities of color. The survey then introduced the problem of gun violence using the same first paragraph as the critical and individual conditions. The control participants followed the same survey path as the critical and individual conditions.

Measures

Punitive policy support. I created a composite measure of punitive policy support by averaging participants’ scores on four polling questions on attitudes towards policies intended to deter crime through threats of carceral or financial punishment ($\alpha = 0.81$). The policy items were introduced by saying, “Here are some programs and proposals being discussed in the U.S. today,” and asked participants to rate the extent to which they opposed or favored each policy on a scale (strongly oppose = 1; strongly favor = 4). The punitive policies included: more police on the streets, longer jail terms for those convicted of violent crimes, more prisons and fewer opportunities for parole, and increased criminal penalties for non-violent crimes (i.e., property crimes and theft).

Restorative policy support. Similarly, the restorative policy support measure averaged scores on polling questions on policies that invested resources in promoting positive structural supports and removing a structural barrier to employment. Participants were asked to indicate whether they opposed or favored the following policies on a scale from 1 (strongly oppose) to 4 (strongly favor): more community programs for young people, job programs for people in the inner-cities, more federal assistance to the poor, and remove criminal-history questions from employment applications. I averaged the items to create a composite score for each participant ($\alpha = 0.67$).

Results

The following analyses are designed to test the hypotheses that (H1 & H2) learning about structural racism significantly impacts support for violence prevention policy approaches, (H3a & H3b) the conditional effect will maintain significance across political orientation, (H4) the extent to which participants invoke anti-Black stereotypes to explain the racial patterns of neighborhood gun violence, and (H5a & H5b) the extent to which modern racism mediates policy support. The analyses consist of multivariate regression models that included political orientation, gender, age, adjusted income, and level of education as covariates. The control condition served as the reference category, and the measure of adjusted income was calculated by dividing participants’ reported annual income by household size.

Punitive policy support The average level of punitive support was significantly lower in the critical condition ($M = 2.20$, $SD = 0.70$) compared to both the control condition ($M = 2.53$, $SD = 0.72$) and the individual condition ($M = 2.49$, $SD = 0.73$). The critical condition significantly reduced punitive policy ($t(586) = -4.79$, $p < .001$), and this reduction was not moderated by political orientation ($b = 0.06$, 95% CI $[-0.03, 0.15]$, $t(918) = 1.26$, $p = .207$). There was no significant association in the level of support for punitive policies between those who read the individual article ($M = 2.49$, $SD = 0.73$; $b = -0.10$, 95% CI $[-0.23, 0.03]$, $t(586) = -1.56$, $p = .119$), or those who read the unrelated control ($M = 2.53$, $SD = 0.72$).

Restorative policy support Similarly, the critical narrative increased restorative policy support ($t(919) = 2.60$, $p = .010$) and was not moderated by political orientation ($b = 0.00$, 95% CI $[-0.05, 0.05]$, $t(584) = -0.12$, $p = .905$). There was no significant association in the level of support for punitive policies between those who read the

Table 1: Descriptive Statistics of Main Dependent Variables by Condition in Study 1

	Control	Individual	Critical	Overall
	(N=226)	(N=181)	(N=194)	(N=601)
Punitive Policy Support				
Mean (SD)	2.53 (0.716)	2.49 (0.726)	2.20 (0.701)	2.41 (0.729)
Median [Min, Max]	2.50 [1.00, 4.00]	2.50 [1.00, 4.00]	2.25 [1.00, 4.00]	2.50 [1.00, 4.00]
Restorative Policy Support				
Mean (SD)	3.12 (0.548)	3.06 (0.530)	3.30 (0.552)	3.16 (0.551)
Median [Min, Max]	3.25 [1.50, 4.00]	3.00 [1.50, 4.00]	3.38 [1.00, 4.00]	3.25 [1.00, 4.00]
Symbolic Racism				
Mean (SD)	0.894 (0.348)	0.952 (0.368)	0.827 (0.356)	0.890 (0.360)
Median [Min, Max]	0.854 [0.285, 1.71]	0.955 [0.285, 1.78]	0.784 [0.285, 1.78]	0.860 [0.285, 1.78]

individual article ($M = 3.06$, $SD = 0.53$; $t(586) = 0.31$, $p = .756$), or those who read the unrelated control ($M = 3.12$, $SD = 0.55$).

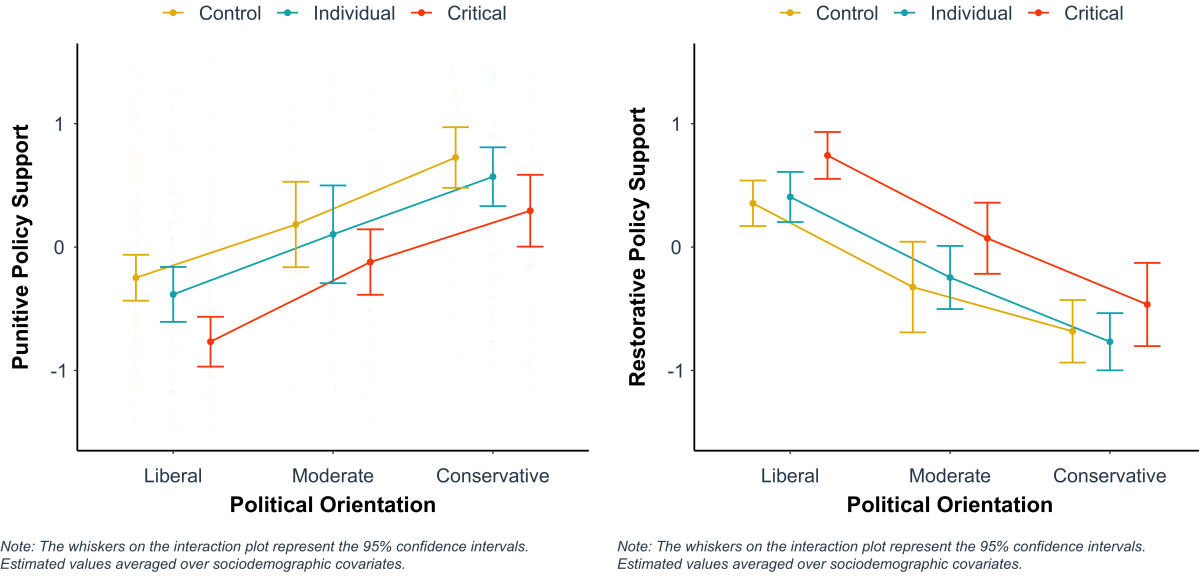


Figure 1: Punitive and Restorative Policy Support by Condition and Political Orientation in Study 1.

Table 2: Regression Analyses Predicting Main Dependent Variables in Study 1

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>		
	Punitive	Restorative	Racism
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Intercept	1.75*** (0.12)	3.70*** (0.08)	-1.48*** (0.18)
Condition: Individual	-0.10 (0.06)	0.01 (0.05)	-0.004 (0.10)
Condition: Critical	-0.30*** (0.06)	0.16*** (0.04)	-0.18 (0.09)
Political Orientation	0.19*** (0.02)	-0.17*** (0.01)	0.50*** (0.02)
Race: Latiné	0.15 (0.12)	-0.07 (0.08)	-0.24 (0.18)
Race: Black	-0.06 (0.10)	0.07 (0.07)	-0.36* (0.14)
Race: Native American	0.31 (0.37)	-0.04 (0.26)	-0.57 (0.56)
Race: Asian	0.06 (0.11)	-0.08 (0.08)	0.39* (0.16)
Race: Middle Eastern	0.002 (0.37)	0.43 (0.26)	-0.48 (0.56)
Race: Other	0.07 (0.32)	-0.26 (0.23)	0.04 (0.48)
Race: Multi	-0.12 (0.10)	-0.03 (0.07)	-0.12 (0.15)
Female	0.16** (0.05)	0.04 (0.04)	-0.07 (0.08)
Age	0.003 (0.002)	0.001 (0.002)	-0.003 (0.004)
Adj. Income	-0.0000 (0.0000)	-0.0000 (0.0000)	-0.0000** (0.0000)
College degree	-0.03 (0.05)	-0.09* (0.04)	0.11 (0.08)
Observations	601	601	601
R ²	0.26	0.34	0.49
Adjusted R ²	0.24	0.32	0.47
Residual Std. Error (df = 586)	0.63	0.45	0.96
F Statistic (df = 14; 586)	14.71***	21.61***	39.60***

Note:

*p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001

Modern racism The critical narrative also reduced participants' scores on the modern racism measure ($M = 0.88$, $SD = 0.31$; $t(919) = -2.52$, $p = .012$) compared to the naïve narrative ($M = 0.94$, $SD = 0.29$). In simple bootstrapped mediation analyses with no covariates, the critically narrative partially mediated the critical narrative effect on reduced punitive policy support (). The mean indirect effect of the critical narrative on punitive through modern racism was -0.15 (indirect effect = -0.15, $SE = 0.06$, [-0.26, -0.04], $R = 0.6$ $R^2 = 0.37$, $F(2, 931) = 267.59$, $p < 0.001$).

A bootstrapped mediation analysis with the sociodemographic covariates partialled out showed that modern racism significantly mediated 21% of the critical narrative's effect on punitive support (indirect effect = -0.05, $SE = 0.02$, [-0.1, 0.00], and 29% of that of restorative support (indirect effect = 0.04, $SE = 0.02$, [0.00, 0.07], $p < 0.001$).

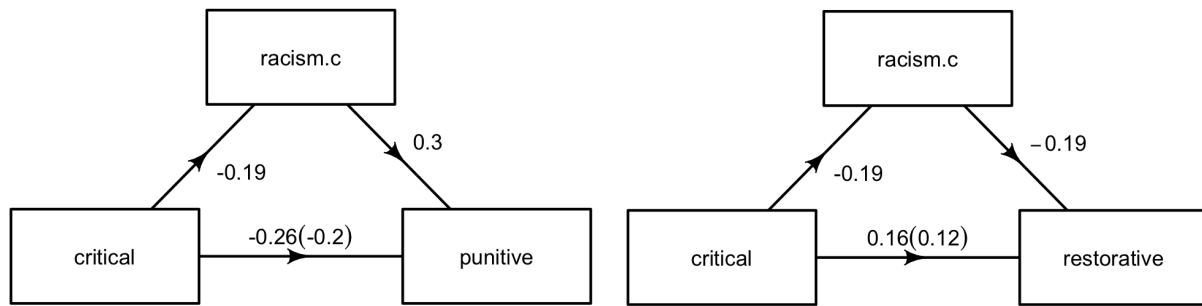


Figure 2: Mediation diagrams of the critical effect on policy support through modern racism in Study 1.

Discussion

This research explored how a critical counternarrative could influence policy preferences by undermining mainstream narratives that are consistent with anti-Black stereotypes. The results support the study's primary hypotheses that a critical counternarrative reduces punitive policy support (H1) and increases restorative policy support (H2), compared to individualized narratives that dominate mainstream media. In spite of the strong,

positive association between conservative values and punitive policies, the critical narrative effects on policy support across liberal, moderate, and conservative participants (H1a & H2a). I also found that the critical narrative caused reduced agreement modern racism (H3). In addition, mediation analyses support the hypotheses that reading the critical narrative affected policy support through a reduction in modern racism scores. (H4a & H4b). One key limitation is that the critical narrative discusses racism in policing and restorative policies, which are not included in the individual narrative. Additionally, the policy support measure solicited participants' general attitudes towards the proposed policies rather than their beliefs about whether they would effectively reduce gun violence. I address these issues in Study 2.

Study 2: Causal explanations of racial disparities drive critical narrative effects on violence prevention policies and underlying anti-Black attitudes

In Study 2, I test whether providing the causal explanation of how structural racism impacts current gun violence is a key to the main effects on policy preferences found in Study 1 by comparing the critical condition to a naïve anti-racist condition. Compared to a critical narrative, a naïve narratives (A) describe marginalized group experiences and (B) proclaim the importance of being against structural racism, but fails to (C) explain the critical history behind it. I also designed Study 2 to rule out the possibility that the conditional differences were due found in Study 1 are due to the critical narrative including recommendations for restorative policies, while the individual and control conditions did not. This study is a two-group randomized, between-subject experiment that presents varying narratives about CGV that conclude with the same set of policy recommendations. The main hypotheses are:

- H1a. Participants in the critical condition will report reduced support for punitive policies. This main effect will emerge across levels of political ideology (b).
- H2a. Participants in the critical condition will report increased support for restorative policies. This main effect will emerge across levels of political ideology (b).
- H3a. Participants in the critical condition will score lower on a modern racism scale (b).
- H4. Reduced modern racism will partially mediate the critical main effects on reduced punitive policy support (a) and increased restorative policy support (b).

Methods

This study was pre-registered on osf.io/e6c2d in Fall 2020 and recruited 934 online participants from Dynata to complete a 15-minute survey ($M = 15.82$, $SD = 6.92$) for \$1.50. The sample was 49% female, 84% White, 8% Black, 3% Latiné, 4% Asian, 0% Middle Eastern, and 1% of Native or Indigenous descent, with a median adjusted household income of \$46,603.75 ($M = 52790.80$, $SD = 31158.32$.)

Materials

After consenting to participate in a study about information evaluation, the survey randomly assigned participants to read a news article associated with the critical or naïve condition.

Critical narrative I revised the critical narrative used in Study 1 to end with new paragraphs that contrast recommendations for both punitive and restorative violence reduction approach. In the penultimate paragraph, the author quotes police experts who recommend investing in policing and prisons to reduce crime. Specific recommendations include investments in surveillance technology, more patrol officers, and equipment. The final paragraph counters this perspective with policy experts who say that policing does not the root cause of violence and then recommends investing in community infrastructure and support services, such as public education, youth programs, and affordable housing.

Naïve anti-racist narrative This narrative was designed to satisfy liberals' social desirability to be "against racism" while provoking reactance from conservatives. The naïve narrative blames gun violence on systemic racism but does not explain how historical patterns of systemic racism contributed to gun violence at any point. I substituted

the causal information delivered in the critical narrative with statistics such as the specific number of homicides per year. The naïve narrative then reports that the nature of gun violence has changed over the years, but our policies and approaches have not. The article then explains how the culture surrounding urban gun violence has changed over the years. Using language from news outlets, the article describes the culture of “Chicago’s many informal, neighborhood groups, or cliques, of young, African-American men follow a deadly code: perceived slights and past slayings of friends by rivals must be avenged through the barrel of a gun... [and] live in their own, isolated culture that glorifies gun violence and warps how they see themselves as black men,” (Science News, 2019).

Measures

After reading and summarizing their respective news articles, the survey presented a series of survey questions described below and ended with sociodemographic questions and a debriefing statement.

Violence prevention policy support Participants were asked to rate the extent to which they oppose or favor the same eight policy items used in Study 1, but on a scale from 1 (strongly oppose) to 7 (strongly favor) instead of a 4-point scale. I created two composite scores by averaging responses to the four punitive items ($\alpha = 0.84$) and the four restorative items ($\alpha = 0.77$).

Modern racism The survey then presented ten items adapted from the Symbolic Racism 2000 scale (E. G. T. Green et al., 2006; Henry & Sears, 2002). The Symbolic Racism scale, sometimes known as “modern racism” or “racial resentment,” measures contemporary anti-Black attitudes that are not overtly racist. I scaled and averaged participant scores across all items to create composite scores ($\alpha = 0.89$).

Results

Table 3: Descriptive Statistics of Main Variables by Condition in Study 2

	Control	Treat	P-value	Total
	(N=481)	(N=453)		(N=934)
Punitive policy support				
Mean (SD)	4.72 (1.41)	4.17 (1.44)	0.001	4.46 (1.45)
Median [Min, Max]	4.75 [1.00, 7.00]	4.25 [1.00, 7.00]		4.50 [1.00, 7.00]
Restorative policy support				
Mean (SD)	4.83 (1.18)	5.04 (1.24)	0.01	4.93 (1.21)
Median [Min, Max]	5.00 [1.00, 7.00]	5.25 [1.00, 7.00]		5.00 [1.00, 7.00]
Symbolic Racism				
Mean (SD)	0.934 (0.245)	0.886 (0.258)	0.004	0.911 (0.252)
Median [Min, Max]	0.949 [0.367, 1.49]	0.908 [0.367, 1.49]		0.924 [0.367, 1.49]

Violence prevention policy support Reading the critical narrative was associated with less support for punitive policies ($M = 4.17$, $SD = 1.44$; $t(919) = -5.72$, $p < .001$) compared to those who read the naive narrative ($M = 4.72$, $SD = 1.41$). The positive association between the critical condition and punitive policy support was not moderated by political orientation ($t(918) = 1.26$, $p = .207$). Participants who read the critical narrative also reported greater support for restorative policies ($M = 5.04$, $SD = 1.24$; $t(919) = 2.60$, $p = .010$) compared to those who read the naive narrative ($M = 4.83$, $SD = 1.18$). This positive association between the critical condition and restorative policy support was also not moderated by political orientation ($t(918) = 0.00$, $p = .996$).

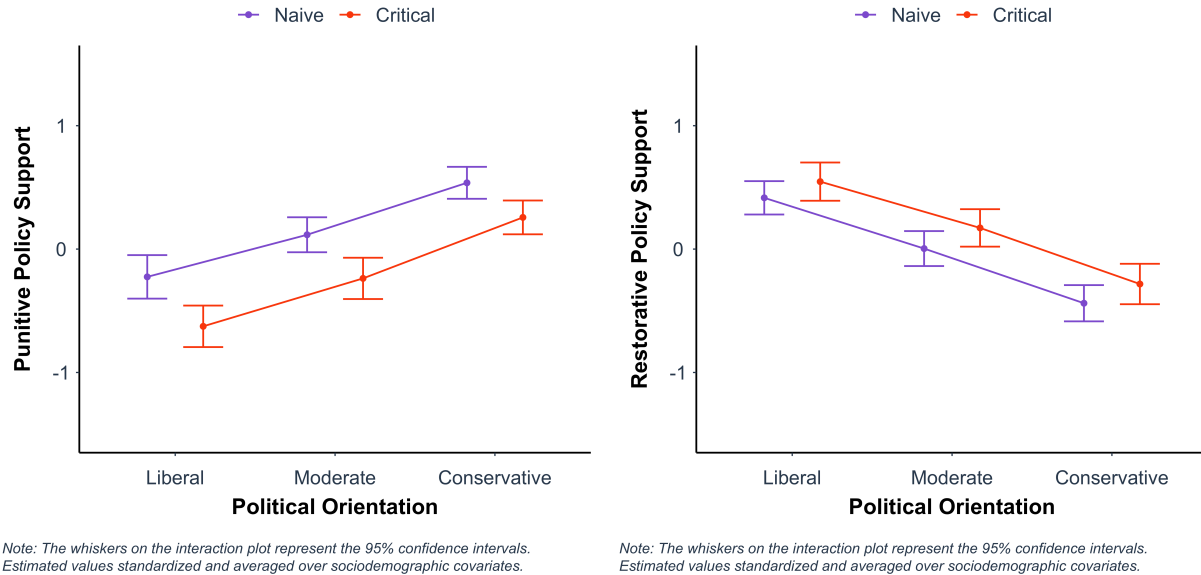


Figure 3: Punitive and Restorative Policy Support by Condition and Political Orientation in Study 2.

Table 4: Regression Analyses Predicting Main Variables in Study 2

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>		
	Punitive (1)	Restorative (2)	Racism (3)
Intercept	3.78*** (0.21)	5.82*** (0.18)	0.67*** (0.04)
Condition: Critical	-0.50*** (0.09)	0.19** (0.07)	-0.04* (0.02)
Political Orientation	0.28*** (0.02)	-0.24*** (0.02)	0.08*** (0.005)
Race: Latiné	0.22 (0.33)	0.19 (0.28)	-0.04 (0.06)
Race: Black	-0.34 (0.18)	0.05 (0.15)	-0.13*** (0.03)
Race: Native American	0.75 (0.51)	-0.40 (0.43)	0.17 (0.10)
Race: Asian	0.20 (0.24)	-0.11 (0.20)	0.06 (0.04)
Race: Middle Eastern	-1.43 (0.94)	-1.59* (0.80)	-0.01 (0.18)
Race: Pacific Islander	-0.99 (0.77)	-0.64 (0.65)	0.01 (0.15)
Race: Other	-0.73 (0.44)	-0.86* (0.38)	-0.16 (0.08)
Race: Multi	-0.38 (0.27)	-0.34 (0.23)	-0.03 (0.05)
Female	-0.10 (0.09)	0.14 (0.08)	-0.05** (0.02)
Age	-0.002 (0.003)	0.001 (0.002)	-0.0002 (0.001)
Adj. Income	-0.0000 (0.0000)	-0.0000 (0.0000)	-0.0000 (0.0000)
College degree	-0.08 (0.10)	0.01 (0.09)	-0.05** (0.02)
Observations	934	934	934
R ²	0.18	0.15	0.30
Adjusted R ²	0.17	0.14	0.29
Residual Std. Error (df = 919)	1.32	1.12	0.25
F Statistic (df = 14; 919)	14.60***	11.90***	27.80***

Note:

* p<0.05; ** p<0.01; *** p<0.001

Modern racism The critical narrative also reduced participants' scores on the modern racism measure ($M = 0.88$, $SD = 0.31$; $t(919) = -2.52$, $p = .012$) compared to the naïve narrative ($M = 0.94$, $SD = 0.29$). In simple bootstrapped mediation analyses with no covariates, the critically narrative partially mediated the critical narrative effect on reduced punitive policy support (). When controlling for sociodemographics, the mean indirect effect of the critical narrative on punitive through modern racism remains significant (indirect effect = -0.1, SE = 0.04, [-0.18, -0.02]).

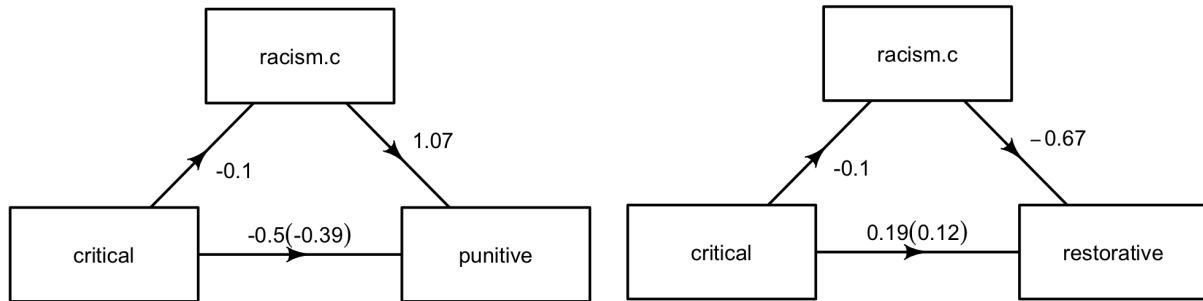


Figure 4: Mediation diagrams of the critical effect on policy support through modern racism in Study 1.

Discussion

Regression analyses controlling for demographic variables revealed that, compared to the latter two conditions, participants in the critical condition reported less support for punitive policies to address gun violence and greater support for restorative policies. The critical effect on restorative support was weaker compared to punitive support. The critical narrative also reduced agreement with modern anti-Black statements compared to the naïve condition. This result along with the reduction in symbolic racism suggests that critical narrative can lower anti-Black affect as it relates to the specific context discussed (i.e., CGV) and as it relates to more general anti-Black attitudes. The results suggest that naïve attempts to signal anti-racist values by just blaming problems on structural racism is

insufficient to shift attitudes across the political spectrum, merely calling out systemic racism is not sufficient to replicate the main effects on punitive policy support, restorative policy support, or racial attitudes.

Study 3: Critical narrative effects on neighborhood violence attributions and a zero-sum policy budget allocations

Calls for adopting restorative approaches have increasingly emphasized the need to divest from policing to minimize harm against communities of color and criticized gun violence reduction plans for prioritizing police investments as the primary response to reducing gun violence (The White House, 2022). Although there is wide general support for restorative approaches, some policy experts stress that policing and imprisonment are still necessary levers for violence reduction, arguing that it incapacitates repeat offenders and reduces the likelihood of sparking a cycle of violent retribution from vigilante justice (Cook & Ludwig, 2019).

To better understand how people prioritize punitive versus restorative policies, Study 3 tests how critical narratives impact policy preferences when placed in a zero-sum budget allocation task about reducing CGV. Study 3 also further explores what is driving the conditional effect on policy support by examining causal attributions that do not invoke racial stereotypes. Study 3 tests whether a critical narrative on gun violence impacts policy preferences by changing whether readers attribute the cause of urban gun violence to dispositional factors (e.g., lack of work ethic, poor values) versus structural societal factors (e.g., fewer job opportunities and underfunded schools). Lastly, this study explores whether the critical narrative may impact behaviors by measuring participants' willingness to share their assigned narrative on social media and their engagement with an online petition in support of a real, community-led campaign for restorative violence prevention. I ran a 4 x 1 between-subjects study ($N = 1392$) that compared the impact of reading a policy memo about "inner-city gun violence" through a critical narrative, individualized narrative, a naïve anti-racist narrative, and a control.

- H1. Participants in the critical condition will report reduced support for punitive policies. This main effect will emerge across levels of political ideology (a).
- H2. Participants in the critical condition will report increased support for restorative policies. This main effect will emerge across levels of political ideology (a).
- H5. Participants in the critical condition will express behaviors and intentions for policy support in terms of budget allocation (a), engagement with a related petition (b), and willingness to share the gun violence narrative on social media (c).
- H6. The critical condition will increase the extent to which attribute gun violence to structural factors (a) and decrease attributions to dispositional factors (b).
- H7. Structural attributions for CGV will partially mediate the critical main effects on reduced punitive policy (a) support and increased restorative policy support (b).

Methods

This study was pre-registered before data collection on AsPredicted.org (#104886) in the summer of 2022. Participants recruited from Prolific were asked to complete a 15-minute online survey about information evaluation for \$3 as financial compensation ($M = 18.32$ mins, $SD = 10.49$ mins). There were no significant differences in the time it took to complete the survey between the critical condition and the individual condition, which were the conditions that were designed to be equal in length ($t(726.50) = -1.41$, $p = .159$). The sample was 49% female, 77% White, 9% Black, 9% Latiné, 10% Asian, 1% Middle Eastern, and 2% of Native or Indigenous descent, with a median adjusted household income of \$37,527.77 and a mean of $M = 43985.67$, $SD = 27453.25$. The survey randomly assigned participants to read one of four study conditions: critical, individual, naïve, and control.

Materials

The manipulations for Study 3 were presented as policy memos from the University of Chicago Harris School of Public Policy. The subject line read: "Gun Violence in America's Poor Neighborhoods of Color" and included the same fake author name used in previous manipulations. See Study 3 Appendix for full materials.

Control narrative The control memo only includes the introductory and closing paragraphs matched across conditions. The introductory paragraph explicitly sidesteps the dominant topics discussed concerning gun violence (i.e., gun control and mass shootings) to introduce the problem of gun violence in poor neighborhoods of color in major cities. The closing paragraphs present two policy approaches for reducing gun violence: a punitive approach (e.g., increased law enforcement, policing technology, harsher punishments) and a restorative approach (e.g., affordable housing regulations, funding public education, and local businesses).

Critical narrative After the introductory paragraph, the critical memo questions why there exists a racial pattern in gun homicides and what can be done about it. It then explains how historical patterns of systemic racism contributed to this problem. This content of the present critical narrative differs slightly from the past iterations. I revised the paragraph discussing how policing targeted black communities for drug-related offenses to avoid triggering threats to conservative, white identities.

Individual narrative The policy memo associated with the individual condition was adapted from the news article stimuli used in Study 1. The memo content describes the “psychological roots” of gun violence and provides a social analysis, a style similar to the critical policy memo. The memo included quotes about how young boys living in violent neighborhoods are socialized to “look tough and act fast” as a defensive mechanism. The memo focuses on the individual-level behavioral risk factors of youth gun violence without explaining the structural contributors to gun violence.

Naïve anti-racist narrative The naïve memo amplifies the anti-racist tone of the naïve news article in Study 2 while continuing to leave out explanations of structural racism. This narrative was designed to prompt reactance against equity-oriented information by heavily signaling liberal values through the rise in “anti-racist” declarations. The naïve memo follows the introduction with a paragraph citing how experts have identified systemic racism as a cause of racial inequities, including gun homicides. It includes quotes calling for legislators to “acknowledge the root causes of racial inequity... [and address] racist policies that have wreaked havoc on our Black and Latinx communities” (Chicago Mayoral Press Release, 2021). It also describes a growing consensus among officials, institutions, and professional organizations that have called for actions “to dismantle systemic racism, racial injustice, and police brutality” (AMA, 2020). The article includes a statement that invokes the importance of diversity, equity, and inclusion to properly understand gun violence” to amplify the anti-racist rhetoric (Everytown, 2021). Rather than include filler content that could introduce potential confounds, I did not attempt to match the length of the critical narrative.

After reading their respective memos, the survey asked participants to summarize the policy memo in their own words and presented bullet points of key points from the reading for reference. This open-ended question was used as an attention and manipulation check. No participants were excluded based on their summaries. After summarizing, they answered a series of survey questions. After answering the main survey questions described below, participants answered sociodemographic questions, were debriefed, and compensated through Prolific.

Measures

Violence prevention policy support I asked participants to rate the extent to which they oppose or favor policies on a scale from 1 (strongly oppose) to 7 (strongly favor). Half of the items were punitive, and the other half were restorative.

Composite scores were created for each participant by averaging their responses to the items within the respective punitive and restorative policy categories. The punitive items included items: more police on the street to arrest criminals, longer prison sentences and fewer opportunities for parole, an increase in the severity of criminal penalties and fines, invest in technology to identify and target criminals, investment in police-community programs to increase crime tips, and seize property from suspected gang members ($\alpha = 0.91$). The restorative items included: more afterschool programs to keep at-risk youth out of trouble, more mental health services and socioemotional support programs, more economic development programs to create jobs, invest in community-led peacekeeping organizations, greater financial investment to revitalize poor neighborhoods, and more affordable housing options ($\alpha = 0.86$).

Budget allocation task I asked participants to allocate a percentage of a budget across two proposals: “Fund community-led programs to revitalize neighborhoods affected by gun violence by investing in jobs, affordable housing, mental health services, education, and crisis response teams,” and “Fund law enforcement programs such as officer training, gang intelligence units, and police patrols to get more violent criminals off of the streets in neighborhoods affected by gun violence.” The presentation order of the options was counterbalanced.

Willingness to share policy memo Participants were shown a screenshot of the policy memo with social media icons and asked, “If you had the opportunity, how likely would you be to share this memo with your friends?” on a scale of 1 (extremely unlikely) to 7 (extremely likely).

Petition engagement I offered participants an opportunity to sign a petition that calls for Chicago to invest in community-led support structures as a violence prevention strategy. I asked participants to rate their interest in signing the petition on a scale of 1 = “definitely not” to 5 = “definitely yes.” Participants who rated a 3 or higher were then shown the link to sign the petition, which opened as a new tab in the background. On the next page, I then asked the group of participants who viewed the link to answer if they had signed the petition (1=“yes, I signed it,” 2=“not yet,” 3=“no, I do not plan to sign it.”)

Attributions for urban gun violence Participants were asked to rate the importance of various factors in explaining gun violence on a scale of 1 (not at all an important factor) to 5 (extremely important factor). The list included six dispositional causes relating to personal character and invoked essentialism, such as “some people have a criminal nature” and “some people are just more aggressive.” They also included historically anti-Black stereotypes of individual deficiencies such as poor parenting, low moral character, and “cultures that glorify violence.” The structural causes included items that reflected societal institutions and socioeconomic landscape issues. These included recognition of structural racism, such as “a history of racial discrimination in policy-making,” “less access to good quality schools,” and “damage to families from mass incarceration.” I created two composite scores to measure the extent to which participants attribute this problem to the residents’ dispositional factors ($\alpha = 0.94$) and structural factors ($\alpha = 0.94$).

Results and Discussion

Violence prevention policy support When controlling for political orientation, race, gender, age, adjusted income, and education, only the critical condition maintained a significant main effect (β), which showed a reduction in punitive support that was not moderated by political orientation (β). There was a significant reduction for those in the critical condition ($M = 6.18$, $SD = 0.88$; $t(1471) = 2.41$, $p = .016$) and no main effect of the individual condition ($M = 6.08$, $SD = 0.99$; $t(1488) = 1.00$, $p = .318$) or the naïve condition ($M = 6.05$, $SD = 0.95$; $t(1488) = 0.68$, $p = .494$). The main effect of the critical narrative was not moderated by political orientation, and there were no significant interactions between political orientation and any of the conditions. ($t(1468) = 0.38$, $p = .702$).

Zero-sum budget allocation task Participants in the critical condition were the least likely to allocate funds to the police budget versus the community investment budget ($M = 26.52$, $SD = 22.09$; $t(1471) = -3.83$, $p < .001$), compared to the naïve ($M = 29.30$, $SD = 23.73$; $t(1471) = -2.87$, $p = .004$), individual ($M = 28.01$, $SD = 21.99$; $t(1471) = -2.54$, $p = .011$), and control conditions ($M = 32.64$, $SD = 24.92$). Results showed a significant decrease in the percentage of budget that was allocated to policing for those in the critical condition ($t(1471) = -3.83$, $p < .001$), the individual condition ($t(1471) = -2.54$, $p = .011$), and the naïve condition ($t(1471) = -2.87$, $p = .004$). This main effect was not moderated by political orientation in the critical condition ($t(1468) = -1.71$, $p = .087$).

Willingness to share policy memo Participants in the critical condition were the most willing to share the assigned policy memo with friends and followers ($M = 4.77$, $SD = 1.78$; $t(1471) = 5.93$, $p < .001$). There was no main effect of the individual condition ($M = 4.15$, $SD = 2.00$; $t(1471) = 1.39$, $p = .165$) or the naïve condition ($M = 4.15$, $SD = 2.00$; $t(1471) = 0.48$, $p = .635$). There were no significant interactions between political orientation and any of the conditions.

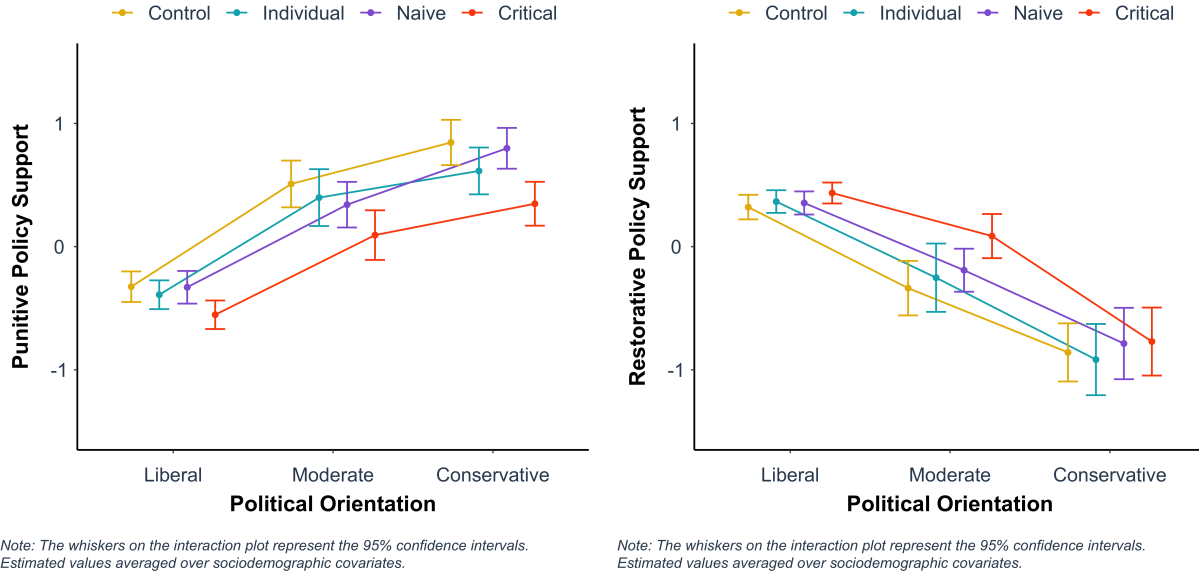


Figure 5: Support for punitive and restorative gun violence policies by condition and political orientation.

Table 5: Regression Analyses Predicting Main Dependent Variables in Study 3

	Dependent variable:				
	Punitive (1)	Restorative (2)	Police Budget (3)	Attrib: Disp (4)	Attrib: Struct (5)
Intercept	1.75*** (0.15)	7.05*** (0.09)	-2.39 (2.09)	1.55*** (0.10)	4.99*** (0.08)
Condition: Individual	-0.16 (0.10)	0.01 (0.06)	-3.39* (1.33)	0.08 (0.06)	0.03 (0.05)
Condition: Naive	-0.06 (0.10)	0.06 (0.06)	-3.80** (1.32)	-0.06 (0.06)	0.11* (0.05)
Condition: Critical	-0.48*** (0.10)	0.14* (0.06)	-5.11*** (1.33)	-0.22*** (0.06)	0.22*** (0.05)
Political Orientation	0.48*** (0.02)	-0.29*** (0.01)	7.78*** (0.28)	0.35*** (0.01)	-0.31*** (0.01)
Race: Latiné	0.28 (0.16)	-0.06 (0.09)	4.53* (2.16)	0.23* (0.10)	0.09 (0.09)
Race: Black	0.21 (0.13)	0.17* (0.08)	-2.00 (1.86)	0.25** (0.09)	0.21** (0.07)
Race: Native American	0.55 (0.66)	-0.62 (0.39)	7.56 (9.13)	0.16 (0.43)	-0.58 (0.37)
Race: Asian	0.43** (0.13)	-0.04 (0.08)	2.72 (1.83)	0.25** (0.09)	0.04 (0.07)
Race: Middle Eastern	-0.38 (0.54)	0.58 (0.32)	-8.68 (7.47)	-0.39 (0.35)	0.69* (0.30)
Race: Other	-0.35 (0.54)	-0.83** (0.32)	-1.03 (7.46)	0.52 (0.35)	-0.30 (0.30)
Race: Multi	-0.10 (0.13)	-0.08 (0.08)	-2.37 (1.75)	0.17* (0.08)	0.11 (0.07)
Female	0.03 (0.07)	0.13** (0.04)	-0.27 (0.96)	-0.07 (0.05)	0.12** (0.04)
Age	0.02*** (0.003)	-0.001 (0.002)	0.21*** (0.04)	0.01*** (0.002)	-0.003* (0.001)
Adj. Income	0.00* (0.00)	-0.00** (0.00)	0.00* (0.00)	-0.00 (0.00)	-0.00* (0.00)
College degree	-0.06 (0.08)	-0.04 (0.05)	0.68 (1.06)	-0.08 (0.05)	-0.05 (0.04)
Observations	1,487	1,487	1,487	1,487	1,487
R ²	0.34	0.32	0.40	0.36	0.39
Adjusted R ²	0.33	0.32	0.39	0.36	0.39
Residual Std. Error (df = 1471)	1.32	0.78	18.18	0.86	0.73
F Statistic (df = 15; 1471)	50.66***	47.00***	65.28***	55.53***	63.63***

Note:

*p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001

Petition engagement The critical condition predicted a significant increase in interest in signing the community-led petition ($t(1471) = 2.42, p = .016$), compared to the individual ($t(1471) = 1.03, p = .301$) and naïve conditions ($t(1471) = 1.24, p = .216$). There were no significant interactions between political orientation and any of the conditions. There was no main effect of condition, however, on whether participants clicked the link to sign the petition ($t(1471) = 0.83, p = .406$), and on whether or not participants signed it ($t(1037) = -1.92, p = .055$).

Attributions for urban gun violence

Structural attributions. Regression analyses showed a significant increase in structural attributions as a function of the critical condition ($t(1471) = 4.07, p < .001$) and of the naive condition ($t(1471) = 2.11, p = .035$). Structural attributions partially mediated 36.86% of the critical effect on punitive policy support ($ACME = -0.175, [-0.266, -0.08], p < 0.00$). They also partially mediated restorative policy support ($ACME = 0.162, [0.079, 0.246] p < 0.01$). I ran an exploratory analysis of structural attributions mediating budget allocation and found a significant partial mediation (.)

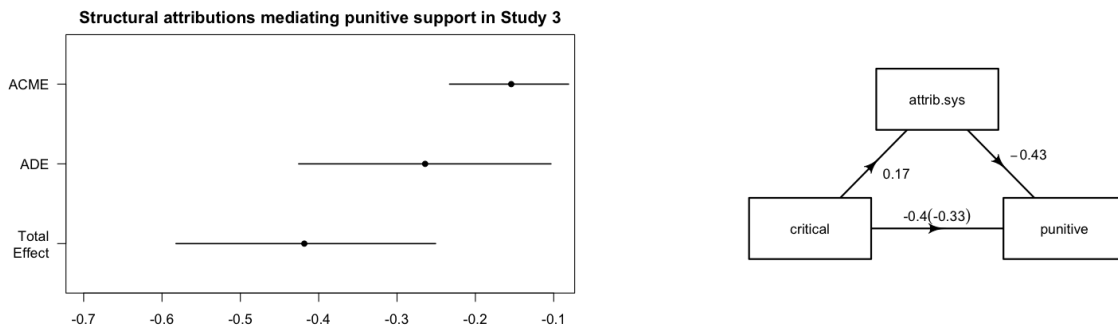


Figure 6: Mediation diagrams of the critical effect on punitive policy support through structural attributions in Study 3.

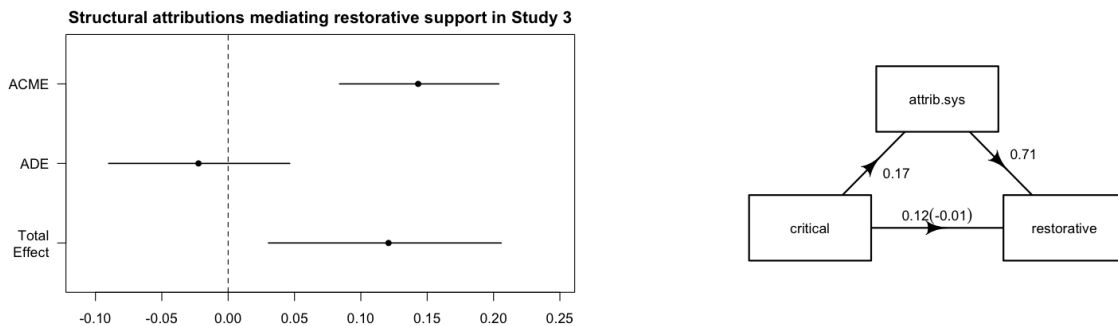


Figure 7: Mediation plot of the critical effect on restorative policy support through structural attributions in Study 3.

Dispositional attributions. Participants who read the critical policy memo were also significantly less likely to rate individual, dispositional traits and characteristics as an important causal factor driving gun violence in poor neighborhoods ($M = 2.56, SD = 1.05; t(1471) = -3.48, p = .001$), compared to the control ($M = 2.81, SD = 1.11$), individual ($M = 2.83, SD = 1.03; t(1471) = 1.26, p = .207$) and naive condition ($M = 2.76, SD = 1.10; t(1471) = -1.03, p = .302$).

Dispositional attributions partially mediated punitive policy support (.), restorative policy support (.), and budget allocations (.)

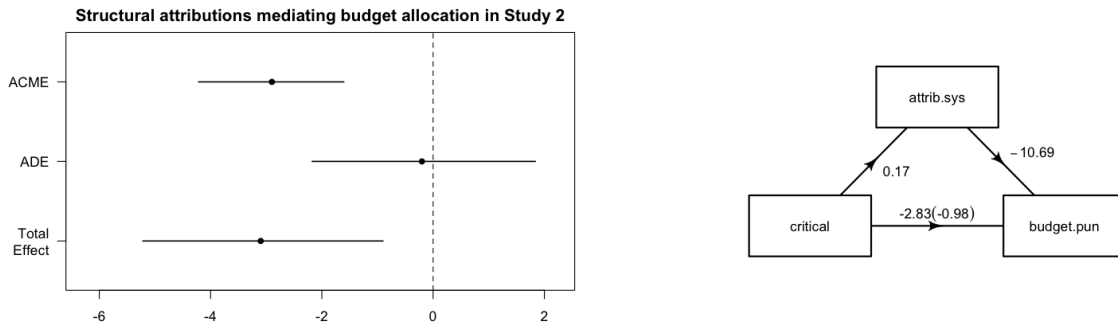


Figure 8: Mediation plot of the critical effect on policy support through structural attributions in Study 3.

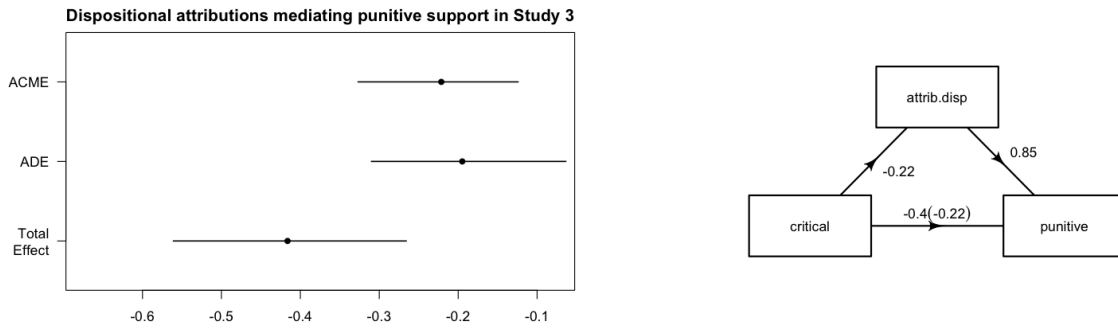


Figure 9: Mediation diagrams of the critical effect on punitive policy support through dispositional attributions in Study 3.

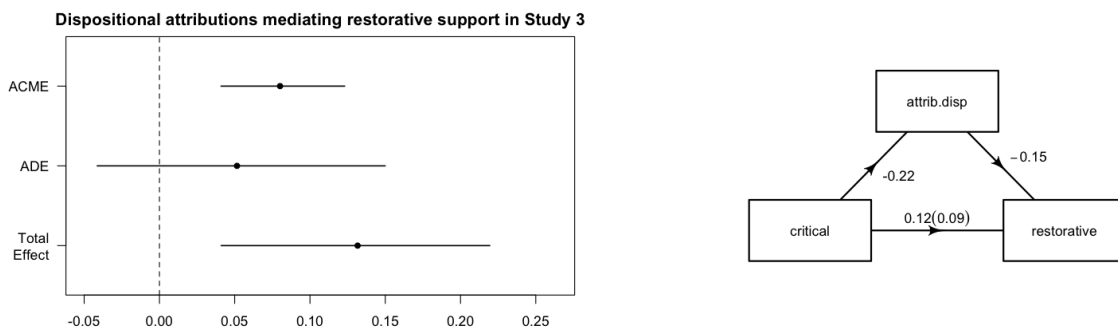


Figure 10: Mediation plot of the critical effect on restorative policy support through dispositional attributions in Study 3.

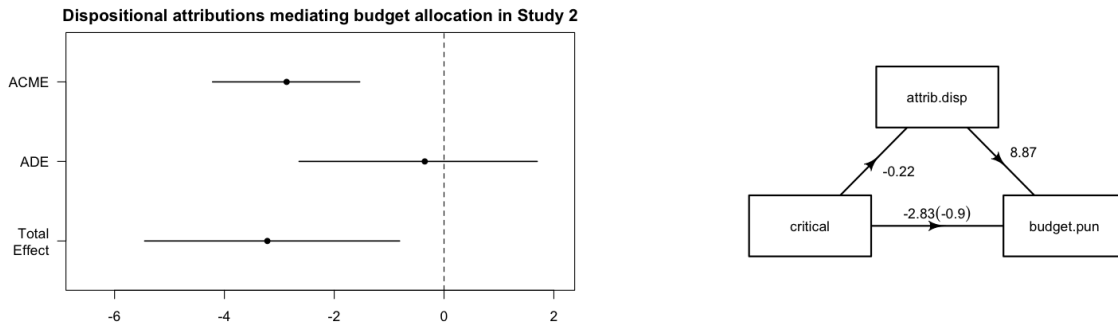


Figure 11: Mediation plot of the critical effect on policy support through dispositional attributions in Study 3.

Proposed Study 4: Replicating critical narrative effects across race and political orientation using a nationally representative probability sample

Study 4 will be a pre-registered attempt to replicate the main effects of the critical narrative on policy support and racial attitudes using a nationally-representative probability sample of U.S. participants (N = 1,500) in a 3x1 between-subjects design.

The main hypotheses include:

1. The critical condition will report reduced support for punitive approaches to gun violence prevention compared to the control conditions (no-treatment control and individualized narrative), and this main effect will be sustained across levels of (H1b) political orientation and (H1c) critical consciousness.
2. The critical condition will report increased support for restorative policies compared to the control conditions, and this main effect will be sustained across levels of (H2b) political orientation.
3. When asked to allocate a percentage of a new violence prevention budget between investing in safety through police and community development, the critical condition will allocate a smaller percentage to policing compared to the control conditions.
4. The critical condition will increase willingness to share the policy memo on social media compared to the control conditions.
5. The main effects of critical condition on (a) punitive support and (b) restorative support will be sustained after a one-week period.

This study will also include pre-measures of theoretically-relevant moderators that may include self-reported political orientation, voting history, exposure to news, trust in media news reporting, information-seeking tendency, urban versus rural residence, social media use, and civic engagement (e.g., attended a protest, contacted representatives, volunteered for a political campaign).

Methods

Participants

Procedure

I will run the study through NORC AmeriSpeak in two waves with a total of 1,500 participants. The first survey will be 15 minutes in length and the second survey will be 5 minutes in length and conducted two weeks after the first survey round.

Materials

Chapter 1 General Discussion

Chapter 1 explored how the (lack of) critical perspectives in mainstream policy conversations about street gun violence in Black communities influences the public's racial attitudes and policy preferences. Results suggest that a critical narrative about the U.S. history of structural racism against Black Americans can change how people of all political orientations view the problem of gun violence among communities of color, which then affects which public policies they support. Specifically, after learning how structures in the U.S. economic and criminal justice system restrict have historically exploited Black communities, they show less support for the punitive policies that are “tough on crime” and aim to get the dangerous criminals out of society while garnering support for progressive policies that aim to reduce crime by repairing structural disadvantages. Across the completed studies, the critical condition significantly reduced punitive policy support and increased restorative support, albeit to a lesser degree. These main effects were not moderated by political orientation. These findings suggest that a wisely-crafted critique of controversial mainstream narratives can serve as a tool to deliver information about politically-divisive topics, such as structural racism in gun violence, in a way that reconstrues how the public perceives and responds to racial inequities.

Limitations Studies 1 through 3 used an online convenience sample that limits the diversity of our participant pool. As a result, this study is underpowered to detect whether racial and class identities would replicate the non-moderation of political identities. Past studies exploring determinants of policy preferences have significant differences between white and Black participants' support for racialized policies. The stimuli were modeled after existing journalism and academic articles to mimic the experience of learning information about current events through news outlets. A consequence of this approach is that the stimuli can introduce confounds into the design by activating other psychological processes that we did not measure. I also did not counterbalance the presentation of the article's punitive and restorative expert recommendations or the order between survey sections.

Implications Investigations of how the public understands the causal mechanisms that produce social problems can unlock insights that build support for evidence-based public policy solutions. The widening political divide in the U.S. demonstrates the need for evidence-based guidance on promoting accessible, anti-racist discourse surrounding societal problems, such as gun violence and racism. This trend showcases the urgent need for empirical research revealing the benefits of evaluating racial disparities from a critical lens that is grounded in an understanding of how structural racism impacts opportunities and behavior. Evidence that the critical narrative is effective among both liberals and conservatives provides insight into building bipartisan support for equitable policies. Addressing the root causal mechanisms of societal disparities is foundational for developing efficient and sustainable anti-racist policy solutions. However, passing and implementing policy solutions depends on public awareness and support. The findings thus far highlight the importance of substantively explaining the causal connection between systemic racism and relevant societal problems to to advance equitable solutions.

Ch 2: Using Critical Narratives to Engage Youth in Violence Prevention

A critical approach can compliment youth violence intervention programs that offer individual support services by increasing the appeal of prosocial engagement by using narratives that are (1) critically-conscious and (2) tailored to youths' experiences. Specifically, I expect a critical narrative to change how societal problems, like poverty and CGV, are understood by the youth living in affected neighborhoods. A narrative that can increase critical consciousness and the appeal of community engagement as a means to address the system-level risk factors for violence. I propose to test the effect of a critical narrative that exposes how gun violence is a product of structural racism and a tool of oppression against communities of color. I plan to do this by (a) aligning the narrative with adolescent values, (b) promoting critical consciousness to address the overlooked structural contributors to CGV, (c) developing skills that empower youth to navigate these structures, and (d) inviting youth to join the present research project as intellectual contributors. The following section describes the assumptions behind the present approach.

Critical components for adolescent behavior change

Alignment with adolescent values Traditional approaches to youth behavior change tend to be effective for children but fail to persuade adolescents (Hardy, 2002; Yeager et al., 2018). A common approach to dissuade risky behavior among teens is to appeal to self-interest by reminding them to make smart choices that will pay off in the future. This approach conflicts with the values associated with adolescence as a developmental stage, such as asserting autonomy, gaining respect from peers, and having a purpose that is greater than oneself, like social justice (Dahl et al., 2018; Damon et al., 2003; Yeager et al., 2018). Developing a sense of purpose that fuels social justice-oriented actions is a promising approach to behavior change. Adopting prosocial behavior to fight against unfair problems satisfies adolescent desires to cultivate a sense of purpose in a way that takes a stand against unfair societal conditions, which is also likely to earn respect from other like-minded peers (Bryan et al., 2019; Bryan et al., 2016; Damon et al., 2003).

Promote critical consciousness Recent political campaigns to ban CRT in classrooms advocate for colorblind curricula, arguing that discussing racial inequality upsets youth and is irrelevant. Educational and psychological research investigating the impact of critical education, however, has found many benefits for youth. Although racism is upsetting, critical consciousness prepares youth to understand how society is structured, fosters adaptive coping skills in response, and motivates prosocial action towards social justice (Freire, 1970, 1974). Critical consciousness has also been connected to greater academic engagement and career aspirations among youth with low socioeconomic status, which suggests that developing critical sociopolitical analysis skills may be a potential pathway towards greater socioeconomic mobility (Diemer & Blustein, 2006; Diemer & Hsieh, 2008; Kenny et al., 2018; Rapa et al., 2018).

Harness benefits of civic engagement A critical narrative that promotes civic engagement through raising critical consciousness has multiple benefits: (1) it offers a constructive path for youth to feel empowered and respected, (2) it is an adaptive psychological coping mechanism for facing community violence and racial discrimination, and (3) foster social and physical protective factors against CGV. Civic engagement is an ideal example of positive-risk taking because it provides an array of positive developmental supports, such as a strong social network with positive role models, structured activities, skill-building opportunities, and the pursuit of goals that are personally meaningful. When adolescents participate in goal-oriented, collective action, they experience a sense of belonging and social support that bolsters self-esteem and positive adjustment to challenging experiences (Galatzer-Levy & Cohler, Bertram, 1993; Hope, 2016; Lozada et al., 2016). In addition, a prominent risk factor for exposure to violence is how much time youth spend unsupervised. Increased participation in community organizations will widen youth's social support network to include prosocial role models.

Reframe the construal of guns and respect Guns are often regarded as a protective tool and symbol of power by young boys who must navigate dangerous neighborhoods where those who are unarmed can feel vulnerable (Fontaine et al., 2018; Stewart & Simons, 2011; Wilkinson, 2003). Unfortunately, gun carrying and the presence of guns significantly increase the likelihood of becoming a victim of gun violence (Lu & Temple, 2019). I intend the

critical narrative to reframe gun carrying from a sign of respect to a sign of playing into an unjust power structure built to subvert the collective power within communities of color. Rather than viewing guns as a symbol of power, the critical narrative encourages adolescents to question how gun violence and gun carrying feed into systems of white supremacy. This framing is expected to be powerful because it casts guns in opposition to adolescents' strong developmentally-heightened drive for autonomy from external control and the pursuit of prosocial purpose (Damon et al., 2003; Yeager & Krosnick, 2017). I expect this new construal will reduce the appeal of gun carrying to avoid signaling that they are playing into a racist power structure and increase the appeal of engaging with community organizing as a path to power. Although gun carrying increases the risks of harm, they fill an immediate need for physical and psychological safety associated with living among CGV. We offer civic engagement as a potential path to fill this need, given its psychological benefits and behavioral benefits. The critical message is also designed to redirect frustration from confronting racial inequality to motivation to challenge it through prosocial, civic engagement.

A mixed-methods approach to intervention research

I discuss how the use of design-thinking and youth participatory action research (hereafter YPAR) allow marginalized stakeholders to meaningfully contribute to the design, implementation, and impact of research programs.

Participatory research methods I will also use participatory methods to develop the critical narrative materials to meet this goal. Participatory research invite members of the intended participant population to offer valuable expertise in their experience of the world in which researchers study. Participatory research methods give members of the relevant population greater control over the research process to ensure that the research processes and products provide benefits as defined by the community. Collective engagement and theory-building between researchers and group members with relevant lived experiences help to bring about insights that would otherwise be washed out in traditional approaches that were developed in an inequitable context (Lewin, 1958). This approach also facilitates a full cycle of research that can reveal evidence-based insights for designing appropriate programs and policies. Through the use of youth-led participatory group discussions, this research would provide evidence for an authentic, multi-dimensional view of participants' experiences with CGV. This inclusive approach can be especially powerful when the problem being investigated uniquely impacts certain groups, such as adolescents who are traditionally denied opportunities to participate in meaningful decisions.

One challenge with conducting YPAR research as psychological researchers is that participatory research has been developed, explored, and applied in contexts that includes relationship building, such as schools or community programs. While I continue to strive to build relationships, I want to do so meaningfully and the constraints of my position in a graduate school program and my general disconnection from this problem space exacerbated this problem. So, I pulled from my background in designing wise psychological interventions to explore how I could scaffold youth-led research contributions through brief, iterative design sessions. One downside of this approach is that the full cycle of YPAR researchers engages youth as co-investigators starting with guiding them to identify the research problems they would like to investigate. Given our funding and established scope of the project, I seek to highlight YPAR goals and practices within these parameters to include youth in iterative cycles of interpreting and gathering data to build a the final intervention design.

So, one strategy I'm using is to conduct workshops with youth who are 1) already interested in solving problems about community gun violence and racism, and 2) to supplement their ideation processes by providing an initial set of qualitative stimuli based on our a priori hypotheses about what would make for an effective youth violence prevention message. This stack of stimuli can also include real and crafted material from traditional youth violence prevention material to reduce the amount of researcher bias in how the youth build their representations of the problems and solutions to gun violence.

Human-centered design-thinking methods A key to creating long-term behavior change is to create a message that aligns with adolescents' psychological motivations and connect it to their identity and surrounding sociocultural environment. I intend to use design-thinking to develop an intervention approach that is wise to the lived experiences of youth exposed to CGV. Design thinking methods are structured to suspend normative influences that restrain imaginative solutions (IDEO, 2011). Psychologists have used design-thinking to create strategic interventions to target psychology in a way that catalyzes recursive psychological processes, which compounded

into significant changes in the racial disparity in academic outcomes and in healthy eating behavior (Bryan et al., 2019; Bryan et al., 2016; IDEO, 2011; Yeager et al., 2013, 2016, 2022).

Hypotheses

- H1. Participants in the critical condition will report greater interest in joining youth community programs (a) and in attending a novel youth violence prevention program offered by the research team (b).
- H2. Participants in the critical condition will show greater participation in local community programs (a) and in the novel youth program (b).
- H3. Participants in the critical condition will report more negative attitudes towards guns as measured using self-reported surveys (a) and implicit affect using an affect misattribution procedure (b).
- H4. Participants in the critical condition will report greater agreement with construals of a youth activist as an identity that is personally appealing (a), respected among peers (b), and a way to assert independence (c).

Study 1: The Participatory Process for Qualitative Investigation and Theory Development

Study 1 describes the development of a novel intervention to reduce youth gun carrying. Building off of theories of adolescent motivation and behavior change, I created a brief intervention designed to leverage social, developmental, and psychological factors to reframe how youth interpret gun carrying, youth violence prevention services, and community activism. The intervention's central message is that gun carrying perpetuates racial injustice in communities of color and that civic engagement is a true path to the respect young adolescents seek. I will present thematic analyses from qualitative interviews and discuss how the use of design-thinking and participatory methods for youth to meaningfully contribute to the design, implementation, and impact of research programs.

This study details the qualitative processes that informed the intervention development. I will describe the prominent themes that rose from interviews, focus groups, and informational campaigns from groups and individuals who are either impacted by gun violence or involved in organizing collective responses to gun violence and community issues. This study also includes pilot data from Chicago youth who received the pilot intervention material, answered survey questions, provided open-ended feedback, and engaged in re-designing the intervention material. These are my a priori theoretical assumptions that I seek to compare with youths' experiences through qualitative investigation:

1. Guns are carried as a form of safety.
2. Gun carrying or proximity with gun carriers sends signals about social status or that otherwise deter threats to safety.
3. Activists and community organizers advocating for racial justice are viewed positively. Specifically, that youth view them as appealing identities that are worthy of respect by high-status peers.
4. Connecting youth to community advocacy organizations is a protective factor against exposure to gun violence, and social pressures to carry guns.
5. Youth as young as 11 years old are exposed to and recognize the concepts of racism, social justice, and community gun violence.
6. Youth value (a) asserting independence, (b) earning respect from their peers, (c) social justice, and (d) having a beyond-the-self impact on the world.

Methods

I will compare insights from focus groups, interviews, and design workshops with the a priori theoretical assumptions. I first recruited participants from ages 11 to 25 living in Chicago neighborhoods that have high rates of gun violence. After initial rounds of focus group sessions, I narrowed the eligibility to boys ages 11 to 15. I chose these criteria because gun carrying is more common among boys (Fontaine et al., 2018) and because gun carrying has been reported to begin as early as 10 years old (DuRant et al., 1999). In addition, the transition to middle school that coincides with the developmental shift to adolescence provides an opportunity to explore and adopt new

identities in a new context, which impacts their behavioral trajectory. Strategies to promote positive habits can leverage the nuances of this transition to enable lasting behavioral changes.

Procedure

Participants were recruited through community organizations sharing physical and digital fliers to their networks. The study advertisements were titled “Make Your Voice Heard” and invited local youth ages 11 to 17 to a 1-hour group interview where students share their thoughts on community safety, gun violence prevention, racial justice, and youth activism for a \$35 e-gift card compensation. During the sessions, I introduced the project goal of sharing the voices of young Chicagoans living in neighborhoods that are affected by gun violence to inform the policies and practices to promote community safety. At the end of each session, I invited the participants, parents/guardians, and other interested community members to join the project as expert consultants and co-designers who would be compensated for their time. After rounds of interviews and focus groups, I will host 1-3 workshop sessions in which the research team and participants will co-create an informational video about youth violence prevention that is told through a critical narrative. I will then evaluate the final product’s impact on youth attitudes and behaviors compared to a similar video that delivers a traditional youth violence prevention narrative.

Semi-structured focus group and interviews Interviews and focus groups were done as an iterative process where I will seek (dis)confirming evidence of the theoretical assumptions by asking open-ended questions and looking for answers that converge towards a common theme. The interview guide included trauma-informed interviewing strategies to probe how participants interpret research materials to ensure it communicates the intended messages. I also explored how participants responded to the material to gather support for our expected outcome before implementing the intervention. I conducted focus groups and interviews using a protocol that included a script and guiding discussion questions. Sessions were held in person and over zoom to suit the participants’ availability.

Researchers introduced themselves and gave a brief 5-minute overview of the purpose of their visit and study goal. The introduction stressed the importance of participant privacy and confidentiality and asked participants not to reveal any identifying information while sharing their opinions and experiences.

I will transcribe audio recordings to conduct textual analyses to calculate the reliability of general themes and specific claims related to our assumptions. Research assistants will independently code text for prominent factors and themes. Based on these qualitative results, I will then update our working theory to align with the identified normative beliefs and motivations regarding gun violence.

Participatory youth program design workshops I will also host participatory program design workshops where past participants and newly recruited participants will be invited to co-design the final treatment program. The resulting treatment material and its delivery procedure will be tested in single-day pilot workshops among small groups of 5 to 15 participants. The workshops will include hands-on activities regarding the program’s visual appeal, engagement, clarity, and overall persuasiveness and will ask participants to rate the final treatment and control materials on these factors.

In addition to the program material design, the sessions will include lessons about the research process and hold sessions to brainstorm ideal research designs and outcomes to measure. These sessions will also be a time to solicit feedback on the pilot measures I currently plan to include in Study 2.

Material development

Discussion questions will center around participants’ attitudes and beliefs regarding gun violence in their community and pursuing civic engagement to help fight racial inequality. I aim to sketch the sociocultural setting of areas prone to gun violence, focusing on key factors that may leverage prosocial behavior. I will also ask participants to watch brief videos that explain how the criminal justice system disproportionately targets poor communities of color. Based on participant reactions from the first round, I will edit the videos or create new material that is at the appropriate reading level, excludes or clarifies confusing sections, and highlights sections that garnered the most interest.

Semi-structured focus group and interviews I created the interview protocol based on literature from trauma-informed research methods, cultural competency, healing circles, participatory youth action research, racial socialization, and motivational interviewing. I also adjusted the protocol according to input from community partners and participant responses during qualitative data collection.

Critical intervention pilot The pilot draft was designed with a priori assumptions informed by research from critical race studies, psychology, behavioral science, and sociology. I created a 20-min pilot program that creates a counter-space to traditional adultist approaches in societal decisions that directly impact youth without respecting youths' expert knowledge on what it is like to live with the aftermath. The program engages youth about (1) how youth voices are an undervalued key to solving big societal problems, (2) the "hidden history" of how systemic racism created conditions for poverty and violence in many Black and Brown communities, and (3) (the hidden successes?) of local youth who have been building collective community power as a way to (fight back/take control over their narrative). A video of the current pilot intervention material is available at: <https://youtu.be/31OU5Wx5xwM>.

Preliminary Results

Insights from conversations with participants

Here are some insights from focus group and interview sessions with youth and young adult participants:

- Children as young as 7 are aware of and/or have experienced community gun violence. There's often not someone to talk to about it.
- Some were taught how to say no by their parents. Not everyone has that.
- There is social pressure to join local gangs because there's safety in numbers.
- Youth activities are severely limited by the lack of available local opportunities and the dangers of leaving the house.
- They want more sports and recreational activities.
- Middle schoolers are familiar with activism, but it often limited to awareness of the Black Lives Matter movement online. They are less aware of local community organizers and examples of successful campaigns.
- There is a general understanding of the government's failure to take care of them, but not of specific topics related to critical race theory (e.g., Jim Crow laws, redlining).
- Learning about local youth activism is appealing and motivating.
- Female students are much more enthusiastic about racial justice work than male students
-

Insights from conversations with community organizers

Here are some insights from meetings and interviews with folks involved in community organizing, mutual aid, youth [civic engagement/activism]:

- Much violence comes from petty reasons about respect
- A cycle of retaliation and revenge draws out these small conflicts

Many youth-serving organizations offer a range of activities that directly relate to our message context, indirectly relate, or offer general positive supports. Rather than reinventing the wheel through a novel program, we can make our message goal to increase the appeal of joining community organizations, promote their services, and assist in scaffolding connections.

Here are examples the organizations and range of services they offer:

West Chicago Austin

- Institute for Nonviolence Chicago (INVC)
 - Case management and re-entry
 - Victim support services
 - Workforce development

North Lawndale

- North Lawndale Employment Network
 - Career coaching and employment connections
 - * Job info sessions
 - * Job training, job placement, and post-employment support (Transportation, Distribution, and Logistics; Construction & Building Trades)
 - * Job training program for folks with a felony background
 - * Digital education
 - Financial coaching
 - * Assist with home ownership and avoiding foreclosures
 - * Guests speakers and webinars (e.g., investing, building an emergency fund)
 - * Business solutions team
 - * Cafe for hosting events
 - Leadership development (e.g., entrepreneurship training, financial literacy)
 - Join LLC with locally grown and created skincare products
 - Online Market Pickups
- The BLOC Chicago
 - Boxing training
 - Academic support
 - Enrichment (field trips, college visits, photography, cooking, and more)

Englewood

- GKMC
 - Youth-led activism
- [R.A.G.E. (Resident Association of Greater Englewood)]
 - “Create tangible solutions and mobilize residents and resources to restore our community.”
 - Assist with home ownership and avoiding foreclosures
 - Raise awareness about community events and partners

Proposed Study 2: Experimental evaluation of a community-based critical youth violence prevention approach compared to standard practice

Proposed study

Study 2 is a proposed pilot randomized controlled trial (N = 300) that will evaluate strategies for motivating youth to join a youth program that advocates for safety against gun violence and related attitudes. Youth participants will be asked to watch an information session describing the program using one of two narratives. The control condition will present a traditional violence prevention narrative that is naïve to youths' values and experiences with CGV. The treatment condition will present a critically-conscious narrative that was designed alongside youth exposed to CGV from Study 1. At the end of the information session, I will ask participants to complete a survey that includes related measures, including self-report attitudes, an implicit associations measure, and options to sign-up for the advertised youth program and related opportunities from partnering community organizations.

Compared to the control condition, I hypothesize that participants who receive the critical narrative will have (H1) greater interest in joining youth community programs (a) and in attending a novel youth violence prevention program offered by the research team (b); (H2) have greater participation in local community programs (a) and in the novel youth program (b); (H3) report more negative attitudes towards guns as measured using self-reported surveys (a) and implicit affect using an affect misattribution procedure (b); and (H4) report greater agreement with construals of a youth activist as an identity that is personally appealing (a), respected among peers (b), and a way to assert independence (c).

Procedures

Youth ages 11 to 15 currently residing in Chicago neighborhoods with high rates of gun violence will be asked to participate in a 1-hr study about community safety and offered a \$35 e-gift card for compensation. After collecting parental consent and adolescent assent, participants will be given pre-survey questions to measure baseline attitudes before viewing the randomly-assigned material. Participants will be randomized on an individual level through the survey logic to view the critical or control version of the video using an iPad with headphones. The survey will then present a 20-minute video that encourages youth to get involved in prosocial, community-based programs related to violence prevention, civic engagement, employment-seeking support, and personal development. After viewing the video, the survey will ask students to think and write about behaviors that could help reduce gun violence in their communities, with the critical material highlighting prosocial civic behaviors and the control material highlighting traditional violence prevention strategies. After the writing exercises, the survey will ask all participants if they would like to participate in the youth violence prevention program shown in the video. Then, the survey will ask participants to answer the survey measures described below and conclude with the AMP task.

I will send participants invitations to the youth program at least one week after they complete the first survey. The youth program will be scheduled in advance and will provide multiple opportunities for participants to join in-person and online. I will track participants' attendance at the youth program along with self-reported behaviors and attitudes through bi-weekly follow-up surveys.

Materials

Feedback from focus group participants will be used to ensure the language used in the material is communicated properly, at the appropriate reading level, and engaging. The control materials will be based on traditional gun violence prevention programs that focus on individual reasons and consequences of using guns. Research assistants and focus group participants will pre-test the reading material in both programs to be similar in length, appearance, and reading level.

Critical narrative We will use the treatment program developed from Study 1. To communicate that the new information is valued by like-minded peers, the reading material will be supplemented by positive, true reactions from participants collected in focus groups.

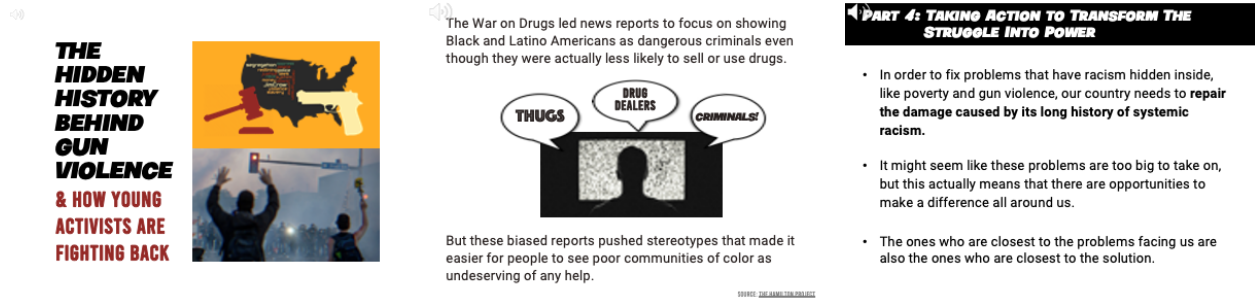


Figure 12: Screenshots of the pilot material for the critical treatment condition.

Traditional narrative The control program video is modeled after traditional youth violence prevention approaches that use moral- and fear-based appeals that emphasize the importance of practicing non-violence to avoid negative life outcomes. The video will end with quotes from parents, teachers, and police officers about how youth are overreacting to disrespect and need to think about their futures.

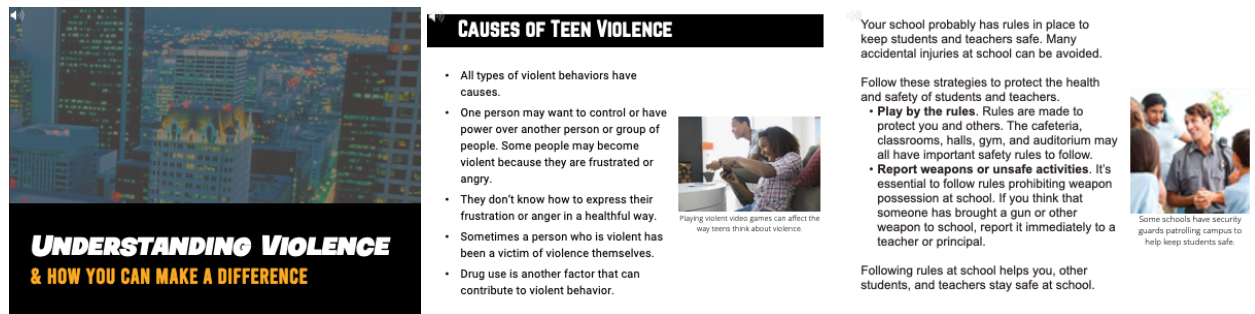


Figure 13: Screenshots of the pilot material for the control treatment condition.

Critical youth engagement program The youth program will consist of educational content and lessons from local community organizers and individuals who have youth-focused skill-building lessons to impart. This may include:

- critical history lessons
- mutual aid and community organizing
- youth participatory action research methods
- leadership and group facilitation
- Socioemotional development and conflict resolution

Measures

Interest and participation in prosocial activities *Critical youth engagement program.* Participants will be asked to rate their interest in joining the youth program described in the experimental information session on a scale from 1 (not at all) to 5 (extremely). I will contact all participants after the study to invite them to join the program, assist in scheduling, and track their attendance rates.

Local community-based programs. The survey will ask about participants' interest in participating in structured youth programs that offer opportunities related to community organizing, leadership training, job-related support, conflict mediation, socioemotional development, and other positive activities. Local partnering organizations presented to participants will assist in tracking participant attendance and related behaviors of interest.

Construal of guns and gun carrying Seven questions will be combined to measure participants' construal of gun carrying as an appealing signal of respect. These questions will explore if participants will perceive avoiding guns as asserting their autonomy or falling in line with social norms.

Attitudes towards violence A composite of items adapted from (Dahlberg, LL.; Toal, SB.; Swahn, M.; Behrens, 2005) will measure participants' beliefs about (a) aggressive behavior and (b) use of non-violent strategies in response to a hypothetical fight. Alternatively, I could work with youth participants in Study 1 to develop an engaging, visual "pick your own path" story that records participants' decisions in a scenario that offers opportunities to choose whether to join peers who are engaged with community activism versus peers who carry guns.

Attitudes towards civic engagement Five questions from the Civic Attitudes Scale will be used to measure participant attitudes towards civic engagement (Voight & Torney-Purta, 2013).

Affect misattribution procedure (AMP) The affect misattribution procedure is an implicit measure of positive and negative associations between visual stimuli (B. K. Payne et al., 2005). Pending participant feedback when developing materials from Study 1, the AMP will measure positive and negative feelings associated with images of weapons and control images of neutral everyday items like a toothbrush (Nosek et al., 2007). The AMP will be loaded on tablets and ask participants to tap whether they feel "pleasant" or "unpleasant" towards images of symbols for 150 trials. Each trial will consist of 4 stages: the target priming image (weapon vs. neutral item), a blank image, an image of a Chinese character, and a mask that remained until a response was entered. This procedure takes less than 5 minutes to complete and has been shown to be reliable and valid under many conditions, including when the participants don't believe the cover story (K. Payne & Lundberg, 2014).

Chapter 2: General Discussion

Limitations and challenges

Researchers' disconnect from community networks I encountered various obstacles in trying to carry out community-based research. Apart from the COVID-19 pandemic, the most prominent challenge was the distrust of [outside/university] researchers due to a history of residential displacement and exploitative research practices with the South Side Chicago community. Our team also lacked structural ties and social partnerships with specific violence-affected communities. There are many and community-based supports typically start from strengthening local relationships around a shared purpose. As folks who do not have direct experience with community gun violence or have ties to a given neighborhood, we were not positioned to fully commit in the way that is typical. Our research project has a variety of goals and standards that we must meet in order to yield impactful, publishable results that are within the scope of our funders' goals and limitations.

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